A SEEKER WITHOUT A MAP

Encounters with Christian Communities in Manchester

Joy Bose

For the communities of this book,

many flowers, one light,

and for the friends who opened their doors.

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The events described in this book are drawn from personal observation and a private blog kept between 2002 and 2011. All individuals have been anonymised. Specific church names that could identify communities have been withheld. The author has made every effort to ensure that no community or person is harmed by its publication.

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A Note on Method

Throughout this book, the author refers to himself as 'the visitor.' This is not evasion, and it is not false modesty about the author's name appearing on the cover. It is a methodological choice.

The visits described here were made in the spirit of a seeker rather than an investigator. Looking back at what those visits produced, a pattern became visible: each tradition was doing something specific to the person inside it. To observe that pattern honestly, it helped to treat oneself as a subject as well as an observer, with the same attention one brought to the communities being described. 'The visitor' is the author in that role.

At a small number of key moments, the book drops into first person. These are moments where the critical distance of the third person would be dishonest. The shift, when it occurs, is deliberate.

Joy Bose

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PROLOGUE

A Seeker Without a Map

I. Who the visitor is

This book comes from a personal and secret blog. The experiences it describes cover the visitor's entire time in Manchester and Salford, from his arrival as a doctoral student in September 2002 to his departure in September 2011. The blog itself runs from 2007 to 2012, but the encounters it draws on — and the communities it revisits — begin earlier, in the first months after arrival. A visitor to the city kept a record of every gathering he attended: lectures, protests, temple services, church meetings, political conferences, cultural events, and interfaith dinners. The blog was not written for publication. It was written to make sense of what was happening, to hold onto details that would otherwise dissolve, to stay awake to a life moving quickly through unfamiliar territory. Several hundred entries survive. Perhaps a third describe encounters with Christian communities. This book is drawn from those entries, supplemented by research into the traditions encountered, and organised around the question that persisted throughout: what does it mean to be inside a Christian community looking out, rather than outside looking in?

But the visitor was not, to begin with, entirely outside. That is the first thing that must be said clearly. He had grown up in a Bengali Hindu family, the annual Durga Puja, the reverence for Ramakrishna and Vivekananda, the easy pluralism that characterises many educated Hindu households of that generation. He had also grown up, from the age of five, in a Catholic school in Lucknow run by the Montfort Brothers of St Gabriel: morning assembly with hymns, the New Testament as a school prize, the prayers and the liturgical calendar absorbed so thoroughly that they became part of the furniture of the mind. He was not baptised. He did not consider himself Christian. But he knew all the songs, and he knew what it felt like to be inside a tradition's daily rhythm, and that knowledge was not nothing. He arrived in England in September 2002 as a doctoral student, carrying these inheritances and a curiosity about religion that was broad and genuine and not yet focused. Buddhism came slightly later, from 2003, but it went deeper than might have been predicted: not because of the philosophy, which he found congenial, but because of the practice of silent sitting, which answered something the other traditions he had encountered had not quite reached. It is relevant to note this here because the pull toward silence shaped what he noticed and what he valued in every Christian community he subsequently visited, including the ones that had none.

What happened next is part of the honest account, and it is told in full in the chapter that follows. In early 2003, some months after arriving, the visitor began attending a Nigerian Pentecostal church in Manchester. He attended for some time. The experience left its mark: when he walked into subsequent Christian communities, he was not approaching them from a position of complete exteriority. He had been inside something. He knew what certain things felt like from the inside. A PhD colleague during these years, a churchgoer of genuine warmth, invited the visitor to Christmas dinner at his church once or twice. These were uncomplicated evenings: food, welcome, carols, the kind of ordinary Christian hospitality that leaves no doctrine and no argument behind it, only the memory of having been made to feel included.

He also had some contact with Jehovah's Witnesses, in 2006, before the period this book covers in detail. He found their earnestness admirable and their theology difficult, and did not join them. The encounter was brief enough to count as a doorstep rather than a threshold crossed. It belongs here as context rather than as a chapter.

By the time the visits recorded in this book begin in 2007, the visitor's religious position is best described as triple rather than singular: Hindu by inheritance and continuing sympathy, Buddhist in regular practice and intellectual engagement,

Christian in a sympathy that had been both tested by experience and deepened by it. He did not consider himself Christian in any institutional or doctrinal sense. He did not take communion in most of the churches he visited, or not routinely. He was not seeking conversion. But he was not a neutral observer either. He was someone who had been touched by the tradition and who continued to find it interesting in a way that was more than merely academic.

This position, the insider-outsider, the sympathetic visitor who carries prior experience but no current membership, is the position from which this book is written. It has advantages and limitations, both of which the reader should be aware of. The advantage is that the visitor could be genuinely moved by what he encountered without being committed to defending it; could notice what was beautiful and what was troubling without a prior loyalty requiring him to minimise either. The limitation is that his own prior experience inevitably coloured what he saw. Someone who has been baptised in the Spirit will notice different things in a Pentecostal service from someone who has not. Someone whose meditation practice is Buddhist will find the Quaker silence differently resonant from someone for whom silence is simply unfamiliar. The book does not pretend to be written from nowhere. It is written from a

specific somewhere, and that somewhere should be visible to the reader throughout.

II. The method and its spirit

The visits described in this book were made in the spirit of a seeker rather than an investigator. The visitor was not conducting research in any formal sense during these years; the blog was a private record, not a fieldwork journal. He attended because he was curious, because he had been invited, because a friend was going, because the event sounded interesting, because he wanted to understand something he did not yet understand. He came as himself rather than as a researcher, which means he came with all the subjectivity and partiality that implies.

The phenomenological approach adopted in this book, asking what each tradition primarily shapes in the person who encounters it, emerged in retrospect, as a way of organising what the blog had accumulated. It was not a framework brought to the encounters. It was discovered in them. Looking back across hundreds of notes about services and meetings and discussions, a pattern became visible: each tradition was doing something specific to the person inside it, shaping a particular capacity or cultivating a particular orientation. The Anglican chaplaincy was teaching the visitor to hold questions open. The

Pentecostal service was working on the body. The Jesuit retreat was working on the imagination. These observations came after the fact, from reading back through the notes, not from applying a theory during the visits themselves.

The book moves in two phases. The first, and longer, phase consists of fourteen community portraits, each describing a specific tradition as it was encountered in a specific place during a specific time. The second phase draws across these portraits to examine three questions that run through all of them: questions about authority, about the body, and about belonging. A conclusion attempts, lightly and provisionally, to say what fourteen encounters with Christian communities might mean together.

One principle has governed the writing of every chapter: the communities described here should not be hurt by this book. The visitor was welcomed, in almost every case, with generosity and without conditions. He ate the food that was offered, sat in the chairs provided, received the prayers that were given, and left without obligation. The least he can offer in return is accuracy and fairness. Names of individuals have been removed throughout. Specific church names that could identify communities are withheld. Where composite scenes have been used to protect individuals, this is done without distorting the character of what happened. No community is

made to look foolish. No private moment is exposed. The aim is to show what these communities are, not to diminish what they are trying to be.

III. Brief encounters

Not every visit made during these years grew into sustained engagement. Two deserve a brief account before the main chapters begin, because they illuminate the edges of the Christian world encountered, the margins where the tradition shades into something adjacent or does something unexpected with its own convictions.

The first is a Thursday evening at a Spiritualist church, attended with a friend in February 2011. Sixteen people sit in a circle, ten women, six men, in a modest room, having paid two pounds each at the door. The guide explains the practice: healing offered through the laying on of hands, or through working with the aura at a distance, channelling the energies of the great spirit or the angels rather than generating them oneself. The rules are precise and respectful: always ask permission before touching, tell the person exactly what you will do, do not diagnose or alarm, work gently, refer anything medical to a doctor. A chain is formed: each person holds their hands alternately above and below the hands of their neighbours, palm facing palm, feeling for the warmth or

tingling that indicates energy passing between them. Two volunteer healers demonstrate, one working with touch, one working at a distance. The practice is calm, unhurried, and clearly taken seriously by everyone present. Whether it is Christian in any conventional sense is a question the tradition itself would find odd: it speaks of Christ, of the spirit, of healing in the name of love. But it inhabits a different universe of assumptions from any of the other communities in this book, and a single Thursday evening was enough to glimpse it rather than understand it.

The second brief encounter happens in June 2011, on a sunny afternoon in Piccadilly Gardens in Manchester city centre. A group of Christians in bright red T-shirts has set up a sound system by the fountain and is playing loud, joyful music, rap, gospel songs, exuberant worship anthems, for several hours. Most of the young people attending are dancing. The music is free. Food is being given out nearby to whoever wants it. In the evening the event moves indoors, to a venue nearby, and continues until ten. The community is one of those networks of evangelical Christians that organise themselves around public witness and service to the homeless and the hungry, offering food and music and warmth without conditions. Whether they constitute a church in any formal sense is unclear. What is clear is that the afternoon in Piccadilly

Gardens is one of the most uncomplicated expressions of Christian joy encountered in these years: loud, generous, public, and asking nothing in return except the willingness to receive it.

A third doorway, briefer still, belongs here. At an interfaith society meeting in May 2008, the visitor sat for two hours listening to an Eastern Orthodox chaplain describe his tradition: the warmth of a faith in which the ordinary world is no less holy than the spiritual, where the question of authority is answered not by a pope or a text alone but by the living consensus of a community across time. The Orthodox chaplain said something that stayed: that the divisions Christians still argue over are issues the church had long put aside and keeps re-opening. He was gracious and unhurried. The meeting was held not in an Orthodox church but in a university room, and the tradition itself remained, for the visitor, a doorway glimpsed rather than entered. Eastern Orthodoxy is the largest branch of Christianity not represented in the chapters that follow. Its absence is a gap in the map, not a judgment on its depth.

A fourth encounter is with a charismatic Christian community known for its communal houses, in which members pool income, share meals, and live together under a common discipline. A visit to their centre in Manchester, with two

friends, found something unexpected: warmth, generosity, a large and apparently happy household that felt genuinely like a family rather than an institution. The people were kind. The food was good. The community was real in a way that many churches, with their Sunday-only togetherness, are not. The community was at the time controversial for other reasons, and the visitor did not return. But the afternoon left the question open: what would it cost, and what would it give, to live one's faith at that degree of integration? The question is not answered in this book, but it belongs in its doorway.

A fifth encounter, spread across several evenings between 2008 and 2010, does not fit neatly into any of the main chapters but belongs in this doorway. The United Reformed Church in Chorlton, a Presbyterian-Congregationalist tradition that merged in 1972, ran a series of informal gatherings under the name Café Spirit: evenings in the church building with Celtic colouring patterns, oil-paint bookmarks made on trays of water, books by Thomas Merton and Anthony de Mello on the tables alongside banana cake and tea. A separate Café Church in Withington, more Methodist in character, discussed Nietzsche and Dawkins over food and then recited a psalm. These were Christianity in its most porous and tentative mode: no pressure, no doctrine announced, the tradition present in the materials and the hospitality rather than in any explicit

claim. They belong at the edge of this book's map rather than at its centre.

A sixth encounter is unplanned and lasts an hour. In March 2010, arriving at Chester Cathedral too late for the tourist information office but exactly at the right moment for evensong, the visitor is waved in without charge. The service is the Church of England in its oldest and least adapted form: a procession of choristers in red, a minister in white, the organ filling a nave that has been used for worship for a thousand years. The congregation is small and sits in two facing rows in the choir stalls, as it has done since the medieval foundations. There are hymns, a reading from Jeremiah, a reading from John, the Apostles' Creed said aloud together, intercessions, more singing. Nothing is explained or adjusted for newcomers. The tradition simply proceeds, as if the visitor's presence or absence makes no difference to what is being enacted. Which, of course, it does not. This is what it feels like to be inside a liturgical tradition that has been practising the same form for five centuries: not unwelcoming, but entirely indifferent to whether one finds it accessible. When the choir files out and the organ falls silent, the cathedral returns to stone and quiet. Outside, the Roman walls of the city are still standing.

An eighth encounter stands apart from all the others because it involves no living congregation, no Sunday service, no

tradition with current members who might be hurt or helped by being described. In April 2011, a two-day pilgrimage to Glastonbury in Somerset offered something different from anything in the fourteen chapters that follow: an encounter with the mythological and archaeological origins of English Christianity rather than with any of its present expressions. Somerset legend holds that Joseph of Arimathea, described in the Gospels as the man who donated his tomb for the burial of Jesus, came to Glastonbury with the young Jesus himself, and later returned to establish the first Christian church in England on the same ground. The historical evidence for this is thin. The emotional weight of the place is not. The ruined abbey, once a building that rivalled Canterbury in splendour before Henry VIII dissolved it in the 1530s, has a quality of layered time that no intact building can quite produce: walls that stop at nothing, grass where cloisters once were, a faint sense of the scale of what was here. Beneath the old church, destroyed by fire in the twelfth century, is a holy well whose water runs red with iron and is locally described as the blood of Christ. The Chalice Well garden, built around it, is tended by a trust that welcomes visitors of all faiths and none. The water from the lion-headed fountain is cold and faintly mineral and tastes like something old. The Tor rises above the town, a conical hill visible for miles, its summit occupied by the roofless tower of St Michael's church. The climb is long and

the wind at the top is strong. The view takes in half of Somerset. Something about the place, whether it is the legend or the landscape or the accumulated weight of centuries of pilgrimage, produces in many visitors a stillness that is hard to account for. It produced it here. A long meditation on the Tor, the wind, the ruins of an abbey below, the sense of standing at a place where the tradition began or claimed to begin: this belongs in the doorway of a book about English Christianity because it is a reminder that what the fourteen communities in these chapters are practising was once new, was once founded in a specific place by specific people, and will one day be ruins that someone else stands in, trying to understand what happened here.

One encounter predates the blog entirely. In early September 2007, days before the record begins, a visit to Enniskillen in Northern Ireland included a Sunday service at a Catholic church where the preacher was Bryan Darcy, a Redemptorist priest well known in Ireland for his writing and broadcasting on faith and social justice. The friend who had brought the visitor there had admired Darcy since childhood. The sermon was the kind that makes the faith feel large rather than small: generous, politically awake, rooted in a tradition that had spent centuries on the wrong side of colonial power and knew what that cost. Afterwards the priest stood at the door. When he

reached the visitor he paused, shook his hand with a particular warmth, and said something welcoming, the kind of recognition that notices a person rather than simply processing them. An Indian man at a Catholic church in Enniskillen. The visitor came closer to tears, and closer to wanting to join the Catholic Church, than at any other point in the years this book describes.

The context matters. Earlier that same day, walking through a Protestant street in Belfast, a young woman had called out a racial slur. It was brief and not violent and was over in seconds. But it lodged. The Catholic streets the visitor walked through afterwards had murals on their gable walls, not the red-white-and-blue loyalist iconography he had seen elsewhere, but images of the Palestinian flag, of Che Guevara, of solidarity with colonised peoples on the far side of the world. A community that had spent centuries as a minority, that understood dispossession from the inside, had found in liberation theology not an academic framework but a lived identification. The visitor was not naive about the complexities of Northern Irish politics, the violence done in many names, the ways solidarity can curdle into its own sectarianism. But standing in those streets, having just been reminded in the crudest possible terms that his skin colour made him unwelcome in parts of this city, he noticed what it felt like to

be somewhere whose walls said otherwise. Bryan Darcy's handshake, and what it meant in that sequence of hours, is one of the reasons the chapter on Catholic Christianity in this book was written the way it was.

These encounters: the healing circle, the fountain concert, the Orthodox chaplain's description of a tradition glimpsed rather than entered, the communal household, the tentative evenings at Café Spirit, the evensong at Chester Cathedral, the ruins on the Tor, and a priest's handshake in Enniskillen, frame the edges of the territory this book explores. At its centre are the fourteen living communities of the chapters that follow.

IV. A note on the tradition

Christianity is not a monolith. This seems obvious when stated plainly, but it is easy to forget when encountering any single expression of the tradition, which tends to present itself as simply what Christianity is. The Anglican chaplain who holds difficult questions open, the UPC sister who has given up marriage and possessions to pursue perfection, the Mormon missionary who presents an interlocking account of cosmic history, the Jesuit who guides the imagination through the Stations of the Cross, the SCM student who argues that the Gospels require a preferential option for the poor, each of these is convinced, with some justification, that they are doing

what Christianity asks. They are also, in important respects, doing entirely different things.

The title of this book's conclusion, Christianity as a family of experiments, is an attempt to hold this diversity without dissolving it. A family shares something: a common origin, a set of inherited texts and stories and figures, a basic grammar of worship that involves prayer, community, and some relationship to the life and death of Jesus of Nazareth. But within that family the experiments diverge sharply. Some try to recover what they believe was the original practice of the earliest Christians. Some try to make the tradition speak to the contemporary world in its own terms. Some try to hold the two in tension. Some have given up on the institutional church altogether and meet in someone's living room with six chairs and a hymn book. Some fill a meadow with sixty thousand people and distribute bread and wine through the crowd.

The visitor who spent five years moving between these experiments was not looking for the one true version. He was trying to understand what each version was attempting, and what it cost, and what it gave. What follows is his account.

CHAPTER ONE

One Name, Many Rooms

An orientation before the visits begin

> *'Is it not curious that the same word should be used for the faith of a Quaker and a Crusader, a liberation theologian and an Inquisitor?'*
>
> , Personal notes, Manchester, 2008

I.

Before any of the visits described in this book, a question worth pausing on: what, exactly, is Christianity? The word is used with great confidence by those inside it and those outside it, by those who love it and those who despise it, by scholars who have spent careers studying it and by people who have never attended a service. It is used as if it names a single thing. It does not.

Consider what the word is asked to contain. A Quaker sitting in total silence for an hour on a Sunday morning in a plain room in Manchester. A Pentecostal congregation raising its voices to a volume that makes the walls vibrate, speaking in tongues, shaking with the weight of the Spirit. A Jesuit priest guiding a retreatant through Ignatius of Loyola's Spiritual Exercises, asking them to hold a scene from the Gospels in their imagination until they can smell the dust and feel the heat.

A Mormon elder sitting in someone's living room in Wythenshawe, opening a blue manual and explaining, with the patience of someone who has explained it many times before, that divine authority was lost from the earth for seventeen centuries and has now been restored. A Catholic bishop celebrating the Mass in a cathedral, enacting a rite whose basic structure has not changed substantially in fifteen hundred years. A student at a university chaplaincy arguing that the Sermon on the Mount requires a preferential option for the poor and that this makes Christianity inherently political. All of these people would say that they are Christians. They are not, in any obvious sense, doing the same thing.

This is not a modern problem, nor a product of institutional fragmentation. Christianity has been various from the beginning. The letters Paul wrote to the churches at Corinth, Galatia, and Rome in the first century already show a movement arguing internally about what it believes and how it should organise itself. The Council of Nicaea in 325 was convened precisely because Christians disagreed, seriously and sometimes violently, about the nature of Christ. The Great Schism of 1054, the Reformation of the sixteenth century, the proliferation of denominations that followed, these were not deviations from an original unity. They were the continuation

of a diversity that was already present in the earliest documents the tradition possesses.

What holds this diversity together? Scholars have proposed various answers. A shared set of texts, the Hebrew scriptures and the New Testament, though the communities described in this book interpret those texts with remarkable latitude. A shared figure, Jesus of Nazareth, though the Jesus of the Quakers, who resist all creed and rely on direct experience, is not quite the same figure as the Jesus of the Latter-day Saints, who appears as a physically embodied, resurrected being whose church was restored through a nineteenth-century prophet in upstate New York. A shared practice of prayer and community gathering, though what counts as prayer and what constitutes real community varies enormously. A shared grammar, perhaps: belief in God, attention to the life and death and resurrection of Jesus, some form of worship, some form of ethics derived from that worship. But even this minimal grammar is inhabited so differently by different communities that the word 'shared' does considerable work.

The book that follows does not attempt to resolve this diversity. It attempts to describe it, from the inside of fourteen specific encounters. But before those encounters begin, it is worth naming the approach used to organise what was found.

II.

The approach is phenomenological. Rather than asking which community has the right theology, or which is most faithful to the original, this book asks a simpler and more observable question: what does each tradition primarily shape in the person who enters it?

Every religious community does something to its participants. It is not merely a set of beliefs held in the head. It trains perception, attention, and habit. It organises time. It forms the body. It calibrates the emotions. It sets the terms of belonging. What each tradition does, what it asks of the person inside it, what it gives and what it costs, can be approached empirically, through patient attention to what actually happens in these communities during the hours one spends in them.

The Anglican chaplaincy encountered in this book shapes the capacity for awareness, the ability to hold difficult questions open without the anxiety of needing to resolve them. The Pentecostal church trains the body in surrender, the physical self is the medium of encounter with God, and the disciplines of raised hands, spoken praise, and tongues are the instruments of that training. The Jesuit retreat cultivates the imagination, the Ignatian exercises ask the retreatant to populate scenes from the Gospels with sensory detail until doctrine becomes experience. The Quaker meeting develops silence, not the

silence of absence but the silence of attention, a learned capacity to sit with a gathered community and wait. The Mormon community forms the whole person inside a comprehensive cosmology, a worldview so internally coherent that it organises everything from dietary practice to family structure to the understanding of death.

These characterisations are approximations. No tradition does only one thing. But the approximations turned out to be useful: they made it possible to compare communities that otherwise seem incomparable, and to notice what each one asks of the person standing inside it.

III.

A word is necessary here about the history of Christianity in Manchester, because the communities described in this book did not arrive in that city from nowhere. They are embedded in a specific place with a specific history, and that history is relevant to understanding what they are doing there.

Manchester is one of the cities that shaped industrial modernity, and the Christian traditions present in it were shaped by that fact. The Methodism that John Wesley brought to the industrial poor in the eighteenth century took deep root here, in a city whose textile workers and factory labourers

needed both consolation and community. The nonconformist tradition, Baptist, Congregationalist, Quaker, was strong in the north of England in ways it was not in the south, partly because the industrial revolution created new urban populations that the established Church of England was slow to reach. The Free Trade Hall, where so much of Manchester's political history was made, stands a few hundred metres from the Friends Meeting House on Mount Street, and the proximity is not accidental: both express a dissenting tradition that is specific to this part of England.

By the time the visits described in this book begin in 2007, Manchester's religious landscape has been transformed again by immigration. The Nigerian and Ghanaian Pentecostal churches that began arriving with the West African student and professional communities from the 1980s onwards have brought with them forms of Christianity that are at once deeply familiar in their biblical references and culturally distinct in their expression. The South Asian Pentecostal communities, the Universal Pentecostal Church, rooted in Kerala and Sri Lanka, whose origins are described in a later chapter, inhabit the same Pentecostal family as the African churches while maintaining entirely separate organisational structures, separate theological emphases, and separate social worlds. The Catholic communities reflect both the Irish immigration of the

nineteenth century and the more recent arrival of Polish workers who came to Manchester after Poland's accession to the European Union in 2004. The Mormon church, founded in America in 1830, has been in northern England since 1837, when its missionaries performed their first English baptisms in the River Ribble at Preston. The Quakers have been meeting on Mount Street since the seventeenth century.

This diversity is not Manchester's peculiarity. It is, in various proportions, the religious landscape of every large British city. What Manchester offers to the account that follows is simply its specificity: these were the communities present in this place, during these years, in these buildings, in these streets.

IV.

One last observation before the visits begin. The communities described in this book did not know they were being visited in the spirit of a comparative study. The visitor came as himself: a doctoral student, then a young researcher, carrying a background that was Hindu by inheritance and Buddhist by practice and curious about Christianity in a way that was more than merely academic. He was not conducting fieldwork in any formal sense. He attended because he was curious, because he had been invited, because a friend was going, because the event

sounded interesting, because he wanted to understand something he did not yet understand.

What that position made possible was a kind of attention that formal research sometimes forecloses. He was not administering questionnaires. He was not observing from behind glass. He was eating the food that was offered, sitting in the chairs provided, joining in where joining in was possible, and paying attention. The attention was subjective and partial, as all attention is. But it was also sustained, patient, and as honest as he could make it.

The chapters that follow are the record of what that attention found.

CHAPTER TWO

The First Church

A Nigerian-founded Pentecostal fellowship, Manchester, 2002–2003

> *'Lord, I lift your name on high. Lord, I love to sing your praises. I'm so glad you came to save us. You came from heaven to earth to show the way.'*
>
> , Praise song sung at most gatherings, 2002–2003

I.

The first thing to say about this church is the music. Everything else, the doctrine, the structure, the social world it created, was secondary to the music, at least in the beginning, at least as experienced from the outside. Before any understanding had developed of what the community believed or asked, the music had already done something. It had made the room a different kind of place.

The church met in a room at UMIST, the university building whose name was already beginning to give way to the merged institution it was becoming, on Sunday evenings from seven o'clock. The room was the kind that universities hold in reserve for student societies: fluorescent lights, stackable chairs, a floor that had seen many purposes and would see many more.

Before the meeting began, there was always the equipment. Members arrived early and carried it in: speakers, amplifiers, cables, microphones, the full apparatus of a modern praise service. The assembly took longer than it seemed it should. Cables ran in unexpected directions. Something was always not quite working. By seven-thirty the sound was usually sorted, and the music could begin.

The congregation was predominantly young, predominantly of West African background, predominantly students. By the time of the visitor's arrival, West African-origin Pentecostal churches had become one of the fastest-growing sectors of British Christianity, accounting for roughly fifteen per cent of all UK Pentecostal membership and rising. The city had been drawing students from Nigeria and Ghana for decades, and several of the city's Nigerian-founded churches had their origins precisely in this population: people who had arrived from communities where Pentecostal Christianity was the dominant religious atmosphere, who found in the church both a continuation of something familiar and a social world in a city where social worlds could be hard to build. The welcome extended to someone who arrived alone, who was not of West African background, who was not sure what exactly they were looking for, was immediate and apparently uncomplicated. No

one asked questions. No one suggested that prior commitment was required before sitting down.

The songs were the point of entry. 'Lord, I Lift Your Name on High.' 'In Christ Alone.' 'How Great Thou Art.' 'There Is None Like You.' 'Lord of the Dance.' They were songs structured for participation rather than performance: simple enough to learn within a verse, repetitive enough that repetition became its own effect, theologically clear enough that what was being said was always audible, always direct. The voices in the room were not trained. They were enthusiastic. The difference, it turned out, did not matter. The collective commitment to the same words, the same melody, the same attention to an invisible presence, created a residue of shared experience that persisted after the music stopped.

A visitor who has spent time in the more restrained forms of Christian worship, the measured cadences of Anglican liturgy, the studied quiet of a Quaker meeting, will find this difficult to account for. The music was not sophisticated. The room was not beautiful. The equipment was not reliable. And yet something happened in those Sunday evenings that was not nothing. It is easier to describe what it felt like than to explain why it felt that way.

II.

The social world the church created around its worship was equally real. There were events beyond the Sunday service: gatherings in people's flats, a trip one summer to an amusement park that became one of those improbable days that lodge in memory, two coaches of young people who had met at a student church, standing in queues for rides they were slightly too serious to admit they enjoyed, eating chips in the grey English afternoon, singing on the journey home. The pastoral care was genuine. When someone was struggling, with studies, with loneliness, with the particular pressure of being a long way from home in a city that does not always offer easy belonging, the response was practical and warm. Food was provided. Company was provided. Prayer was offered, which in this community meant something specific and embodied: hands laid on the person being prayed for, voices raised, a directness of address to God that assumed the prayer would be heard.

The structure of the meetings grew clearer over months of attendance. The first part was almost entirely praise: songs, sometimes for an hour, the room building in volume and intensity as the evening progressed. Then, gradually, a settling. Chairs rearranged or stayed as they were. A pastor or a speaker would take the front. The teaching that followed was scriptural, systematic, and prepared. The congregation was expected to

follow along in their own Bibles, Bibles were carried as a matter of course, and those who had not brought one were offered a spare, and participation was welcomed. Questions were taken seriously. The atmosphere was not that of passive reception but of active engagement with material that was understood to matter.

What the teaching asked of those who received it was clear. The teaching materials used in more structured sessions, printed booklets with scripture references, diagrams, clearly numbered steps, laid out the logic of salvation with a precision that was almost academic. To be saved, in the framework the church presented, required two things: belief in the heart and confession with the mouth. The scripture cited was Romans 10, verses nine and ten. The process was described as comparable to marriage: not something that could be inherited or assumed, not something that could be experienced passively, but a decision made consciously and declared publicly. You had to be present. You had to speak. Faith without expression was incomplete.

This framing mattered, because it meant that the question of whether one had or had not accepted Christ was, within this community, always potentially open. Attendance was not commitment. Familiarity was not conversion. The boundary

between the two was not invisible; it was the most visible thing in the room.

III.

The moment of conversion, when it came, was not something chosen in calm deliberation.

At a meeting in early 2003, an invitation was made. Those who felt ready to receive salvation, to cross the boundary described above, to make the decision and declare it, were asked to come forward. The invitation was not coercive in any formal sense. No one was compelled. But the atmosphere of such moments in a Pentecostal service is not neutral, and it would be dishonest to describe it as if it were. The music had been playing. The room was warm with a sustained collective attention. The pastor's voice carried the urgency of a tradition that believes the stakes are high. Around the visitor, people were moving. The moment had a weight to it that was independent of any individual's prior intention.

What followed was brief. A prayer spoken aloud, repeated line by line. Words about accepting Jesus, about the surrender of the self, about being filled with the Spirit. Hands held. The prayer completed. A sense, afterwards, that something had

been marked, even if what exactly had been marked was not yet clear.

The experience was real. That should be said first, because the qualifications that follow it are sometimes taken to mean that it was not. Something shifted in those minutes: in attention, in feeling, in the sense of participation in what the room was doing. Whatever the structure that produced the experience, the experience itself was not manufactured. It was not performed. It was something that happened, and that left a residue that persisted.

At the same time, looking back, a second feeling was also present, quieter and harder to name. The decision did not arise entirely from within. The room had a structure, the moment had a momentum, and the person standing inside both was not fully separable from either. This is not an accusation. It is a description of how collective ritual works, and the Pentecostal tradition knows this better than most: the whole point of the gathered body, the raised voices, the sustained praise, is to create conditions in which the Spirit can move. Those conditions worked. And alongside the warmth, a faint guilt: the feeling of having left something behind without quite having accounted for the leaving.

These two layers, the genuine experience and the slight unease about the conditions of its production, did not cancel each other out. They remained in place together, which turned out to be important. Because the question they posed, what exactly happened there, and what it means, never entirely went away. It shaped the attention brought to every subsequent Christian community, in a way that was different from what an entirely uninitiated visitor would have brought. The visitor knew, from the inside, what it felt like when a community creates the conditions for an experience and then asks you to name that experience as authentic. He knew because he had been in that room. He did not know what the experience finally meant.

IV.

In the weeks after the conversion, the community was generous in a specific and practical way: they referred the visitor to King's Church, a larger evangelical congregation in central Manchester, suggesting it might suit someone at his stage of exploration. This was a kind act, characteristically undemanding. The visitor attended King's Church intermittently over the following years, encountering there a different expression of evangelical Christianity — more structured, more liturgical in feel, drawing on a different social world from the tight-knit South Asian and West African

community of the Nigerian fellowship. The two communities were in some ways complementary, each illuminating something the other did not show. Attendance at the Nigerian fellowship continued for some months after this point, and then gradually, without a crisis or a decisive rupture, lessened. The reasons were various and not entirely clear even at the time. The demands of doctoral study increased. The social connections that had made the community feel central to life in the city diversified. But the deeper reason was something harder to say cleanly: the certainty the church offered, its clarity about salvation, its precise account of what a committed Christian life required, sat increasingly uneasily alongside a Buddhist practice that was deepening at the same time, and alongside a Hindu inheritance that the church's framework simply had no room for. I was not one thing. The community needed me to be.

The departure was gradual and without hostility on either side. The friendships made during that period remain, in memory, warm. The music remains: those songs are still, twenty years later, ones the visitor can hear without any distance, without any of the reservations that subsequent reflection has attached to the experience of that community. They were good songs. The people were generous. The welcome was real.

What the community gave, and what it cost, and what it left behind, these are questions that the rest of this book is partly an attempt to answer. Not directly, not through argument, but through the accumulation of subsequent encounters with communities that were doing related and different things. The Anglican chaplaincy that would come next offered something the Nigerian fellowship could not: permission to stay in the question. The Quaker meeting would offer silence in place of noise. The Jesuit retreat would offer the imagination in place of the body. The Student Christian Movement would offer conscience in place of conversion. None of these later encounters cancelled the first one. They were intelligible as responses to it.

The visitor who walked into a rented room in UMIST in the autumn of 2002, stood among people carrying cables and speakers, heard 'Lord, I Lift Your Name on High' for the first time, and thought, what exactly? Something worth staying for. That instinct was not wrong. It was, as it turned out, only the beginning of a much longer enquiry.

CHAPTER THREE

The Liberal Chaplaincy

The Church of England: St Peters and its neighbours

> *'The Holy Spirit is also present in such small gatherings. We should ask ourselves if we are living the risk-filled life.'*
>
> , The chaplain, KISS service, St Peters, March 2008

I.

There is a particular kind of Anglican institution that developed in British university cities during the twentieth century: the chaplaincy. It is not a parish, exactly, though it may occupy a building adjacent to one. It is not an academic department, though it stands on university ground and draws its congregation largely from those who study and work there. It is something between a community centre, a discussion forum, and a place of worship, open to enquirers, hospitable to doubt, suspicious of anything that looks like recruitment, and staffed by clergy who have made a specific vocational choice to minister to people in the most intellectually restless phase of their lives.

The chaplaincy at St Peters is this kind of institution. Its building, a converted Victorian house with a library, a chapel, a kitchen permanently involved in the preparation of food, and several rooms available to different student groups throughout the week, belongs to the Church of England but functions as common ground. The Student Christian Movement uses it. The Mandarin group uses it. The university interfaith society holds its dinners here, under the name the Banquet, formerly Abraham's Table: evenings of food and short talks where a Muslim, a Hindu, a Sikh, a Jew, a Buddhist, and a Christian each speak for five minutes on a shared theme, then sit down together and eat. The Buddhist society runs free meditation classes in the chaplaincy library, open to anyone who walks in. A visitor who spent time in both spaces, the Sunday evening KISS service and the Tuesday interfaith meeting, found the same quality of welcome in each: no one asked what you believed before offering you a chair and a plate of food. On Sunday mornings it is a church. On Monday evenings it is a discussion space. On Wednesday mornings at 8:15 there is a prayer breakfast. The chaplains know everyone and are known by everyone, and the quality of that knowing, unhurried, genuinely curious about the person rather than the position, is perhaps the defining characteristic of the place.

The KISS service, Keep It Simple, Sunday, meets on Sunday evenings at 6:30, usually drawing between six and twenty people. It is not a formal service in the Anglican liturgical sense, though it may include the Eucharist. It is led by a chaplain or a lay member, has no fixed order, and tends to gather whoever arrives and build from there. One evening it begins with a reading from the Iona evening service tradition. Another with a reading from the Old Testament that prompts a bible study led by the chaplain: he speaks about the Lord's Prayer in Hebrew rhyming structure, about the parable of the sower and the pressures on the gospel writers to interpret it for persecuted communities, about the two creation accounts in Genesis and what their difference might mean. A third KISS service discusses sexuality and the Song of Solomon, breaks into small groups to ask why discussing sexuality is taboo in the church, plays a contemporary song as a 'modern scriptural' text. The range is wide. What connects these evenings is not a doctrinal programme but a tone: serious, questioning, undefended.

II.

The chaplain who leads most of the KISS services is the sort of Anglican clergyman who has thought carefully about what he does and does not find sustainable in his tradition. He

quotes Romans but mentions that he does not specifically relish Paul. He discusses whether the Song of Solomon should be considered scripture at all, given that it is never read aloud in Sunday Anglican services. He preaches a sermon in the form of theatre: the congregation and Jesus are the actors; Jesus looks at us and smiles and asks us to sell everything and follow him; have we really thought about what this means, how we would actually react? His sermons carry the quality of a mind genuinely working through the material rather than delivering conclusions already reached.

The Maundy Thursday service is one of the most carefully constructed liturgical events encountered in these years. The congregation gathers around a table set with a Seder plate: parsley dipped in salt water as remembrance of sacrifice, unleavened bread, bitter herbs, charoset of apple and nuts and cinnamon, roast lamb, an egg. The Hebrew roots of the Christian Last Supper are made visible rather than being absorbed invisibly into the ritual. After the meal, one of the lay leaders reads from John 17, where Jesus prays for his disciples. The intercessions are led by another: humility, unity, the mission of the church, love, peace. Then bread and wine are shared around the table, each person offering them to the next, saying 'body of Christ' and 'blood of Christ', followed by 'peace be with you.' The final music before departure is a Taizé

chant: 'Stay with me, remain here with me, watch and pray,' which is what Jesus says to his closest disciples in the garden before he is taken away. The service ends without announcement. People leave quietly.

The Palm Sunday service gives each person a branch to carry. The congregation meets outside the chaplaincy first, sings while waving palms, processes inside. The minister divides the congregation into four groups and asks each to consider the same scene from a different perspective: Roman soldiers, Jesus's followers, bystanders, Jewish priests watching from the temple. Each group discusses how they feel. The point is explicit and not laboured: each of us contains all four of these responses, simultaneously. The service then moves to the Eucharist without the observation being resolved.

What the Anglican chaplaincy does, and does consistently, is hold the question open. It does not ask the visitor to accept a creed before entering. It does not structure the service around the confirmation of positions already held. It proceeds on the assumption that the people in the room are intelligent, have doubts, and will be better served by engagement with the difficulty than by reassurance about the answer. The York course on faith, hope and love, a six-week series of recorded discussions between a former archbishop and others, used as the basis for Wednesday morning

gatherings, discusses Richard Dawkins's attack on religion without becoming defensive about it, considers whether doubting is a bad thing (it is not), and allows that a monk who aims to make every activity a form of prayer is pursuing something the same tradition contains but most of its members do not practice.

III.

The chaplaincy is not the only Anglican community encountered during these years, and it is important not to let its distinctive character represent the tradition as a whole. The Church of England contains multitudes, and several of those multitudes make appearances in the blog that would form the basis of this book.

At St John's Chrysostom's, an Anglo-Catholic church in the neighbourhood where the visitor is living, explicitly described in notes as having a liberal bent, the evening prayer service is structured around the senses. On this particular evening the theme is hearing. The assistant priest speaks of a patient whose hearing aid made conversation unbearable by amplifying it; we too, he suggests, are lost in noise and consequently do not hear God. The congregation is asked to close their ears with their hands and listen to their own breathing, then to open them and listen to the surrounding

sounds as an act of meditation. The Lord's Prayer is used in a contemporary rendering that opens: 'Eternal spirit, life-giver, pain-bearer, love-maker, source of all that is and shall be, father and mother to us all.' The congregation includes an Indonesian, a Greek, several Indians, a male assistant priest and a female curate, people of different ages and backgrounds. Everyone sits in a circle in the smaller chapel, which is lit by candles, with stones arranged on the floor in the sacred space at the centre. It is a different aesthetic from the chaplaincy, more ceremonial, more sensory, but the same openness.

The Easter Sunday service at a large evangelical Anglican church is different again: four hundred people, a full church hall, a visiting preacher. The theme is the Road to Emmaus. Two children read the scripture. There are several songs, a collection, the Lord's Supper, communion, a final blessing. The scale removes the intimacy of the smaller services entirely, but the sermon's central observation, that the two disciples walking with Jesus on the road to Emmaus did not recognise him, and that we too may be Christians who do not really know Jesus in our lives, carries the same quality of honest self-examination. We say it sadly; we should say it happily. We may not have received the life they eventually received.

At Hilfield Abbey in Dorset, an Anglican Franciscan community whose land was donated by Lord Sandwich, and

whose brothers and volunteers try to live by the principles of Francis of Assisi, the encounter is different from anything else in this book. This community grows its own vegetables, bakes its own bread, keeps chickens that are let out into the sun each day. It is a place that takes the Franciscan idea seriously: that the holy is present in ordinary matter, in brother sun and sister moon, in the organic eggs and the homemade bread rolls and the fruit juice pressed from the abbey's own trees. The weekend retreat in January 2010, led by a former Church of England minister who describes himself as a Buddhist Christian, is titled "Buddhism, Christianity, and Violence." There are eight participants. The timetable runs from the six fifty wake-up bell to the ten o'clock night service, and in between it holds as much as a working monastery: silent meditation in the chapel at seven, morning Eucharist, breakfast of cereal and homemade bread, three sessions of structured dialogue, afternoon prayer, dinner preceded by grace and followed by silence, evening session, night office. The first session, on Friday evening, is a guided meditation on the passion. Each participant is assigned a role: Jesus, Mary, the high priest Caiaphas, Pilate, the Roman guard, Peter, Judas, the crowd. The instruction is to close your eyes, hold the pictures provided, imagine yourself present as the passion unfolds, and feel the emotions of the role you have been given. What is it like to be Pilate, watching the whole drama from the position

of pragmatic authority? What does Judas feel at the moment of betrayal? What does the crowd feel? The discussion the next morning asks: how is evil justified so easily? The retreat leader works through several traditions' accounts of evil. The four stages of René Girard and James Alison: desire for what another has, rivalry, resolution through a scapegoat, then denial or rationalisation of what was done. The third session compares Buddhist and Christian approaches to non-violence. The Dhammapada on anger. Pema Chödrön on mindfulness. The bodhichitta. The discussion notes how little conflict there is between the two traditions on this ground. That evening, the session turns to Dante's seven cardinal sins and their Buddhist equivalents. Someone observes that modern culture only criminalises lust and ignores greed entirely. The night service closes with a candle procession through the dark chapel, a vivid retelling of the Epiphany story, and hymns the brothers have been chanting in this space for generations. The final session on Sunday morning asks: what is the relationship between resurrection and nirvana? The road to Emmaus is read, the disciples who do not recognise Jesus because they expected something different, who finally recognise him and are filled with joy. The retreat leader holds the two ideas alongside each other without forcing them into identity: resurrection as the earthly nirvana; nirvana as the transcendental resurrection. The Eucharist that follows, with incense offered in a gesture

borrowed from Buddhist practice and bright January sun coming through the chapel windows, is one of the more unusual Christian services in these years. For the visitor, whose Buddhist practice and Christian experience had until now inhabited separate rooms, Hilfield is the first place that suggests the rooms might have a connecting door. The retreat leader's self-description, a Buddhist Christian, is not a compromise or a dilution of both. It is a seriously held synthesis, tested against the texts of both traditions and the discipline of the Franciscan daily office. What it shows, at minimum, is that the Anglican tradition's characteristic openness is wide enough to contain someone who holds it.

IV.

The chaplaincy's welcome extends explicitly to those whom other traditions routinely exclude or render invisible. A talk on forced marriage given by a woman who had been removed from an English orphanage by her mother at age twelve and forced into a marriage in which she was abused, who eventually escaped and made her home in Moss Side, draws a full room and a serious discussion about law, social work, community, and what it means to belong somewhere. It is not a religious talk. It has been given space in a religious building because the chaplaincy understands that the questions it is most concerned

with, about belonging, dignity, and what it means to be at home in a place, do not stop at the boundary of the explicitly theological.

The SCM conference hosted at the chaplaincy includes a session on queer theology led by a lecturer who works through liberation theology, feminist theology, and the specific contributions of gay, lesbian, bisexual, transgender, and celibate communities to Christian thinking. The session is dense and academically serious. It distinguishes queer theology carefully from liberation theology, maps internal tensions within LGBTQ+ communities about the implications of queer theory for gains already made, and asks what each group contributes to the broader theological conversation: the bisexual person's critique of fixed identity categories, the transgendered person's experience of transcending binary gender systems, the celibate person's challenge to the assumption that all meaningful human life involves a sexual partner. It is not evangelical in any conventional sense. It is theology done from the margins, offered to the centre, and received without embarrassment.

The annual Christian unity walk from Salford Cathedral to Manchester Cathedral brings together believers of all denominations: Catholic and Anglican bishops, street pastors, Salvation Army volunteers, the Lord Mayor. A service

in the Catholic cathedral, a walk through the city, a service in the Anglican cathedral. Outside the Anglican cathedral a small group of evangelicals protests against the inclusion of Catholics on the grounds of heresy. The chaplaincy's own position on such questions is implicit in the fact that it has not sent a protest group.

V.

A pilgrimage to Canterbury in the spring, overnight in London, day return to Kent, puts the institution in its largest context. Canterbury Cathedral is the mother church of the worldwide Anglican Communion, the seat of the Archbishop of Canterbury, the site where Thomas Becket was martyred in 1170. Its crypt is reserved for silent prayer. A choir sings in the nave at one in the afternoon. A short sermon in the nave ends with the Lord's Prayer. In the afternoon a visit to the ruins of St Augustine's Abbey, the first Christian building on the site, built by the Italian priest sent by Pope Gregory to convert the English in the sixth century. Augustine met the pagan king in an open field, and by force of reasoning persuaded him to accept baptism. The Norman monks who came after 1066 demolished the simple Anglo-Saxon building and replaced it with something grander. Henry VIII demolished what remained in 1539 to raise funds. What stands now is ruins,

preserved and interpreted, and a cathedral down the road that has somehow survived all of it.

Standing in what is left of the abbey it becomes possible to hold the whole arc in view: fourteen centuries of a tradition that has been destroyed, reformed, argued over, split, reunited in parts, and dispersed across the world. The Church of England is the result of a king's desire for a divorce, this is noted at the York course discussion on whether divorced people can become bishops, with appropriate irony, and it has somehow become the vehicle for the Maundy Thursday Seder in Manchester, the Taizé chants in a candlelit Anglo-Catholic chapel, the queer theology seminar, the Franciscan brothers tending their chickens in Dorset, the carol service in many languages, the chaplain making vegetarian stew in a university kitchen and asking whether we are living the risk-filled life. The tradition holds all of this at once, without apparent strain, because it has learned, through centuries of necessity, that holding incompatible things at once is the condition of its survival.

One further face of this tradition deserves a brief account. Greenbelt is an annual Christian arts festival held over the August bank holiday weekend, since 1974 at various venues and from 1992 at the Cheltenham racecourse: thousands of tents, a main stage, a programme that runs from worship

sessions to art exhibitions, Palestine solidarity stalls, Christian Aid projects, and theological talks on doubt, sexuality, and the politics of the gospels. It was founded in 1974 by a group of young Christians who wanted a festival that could hold together serious faith and serious engagement with the world: music, justice, and theology in the same field. It has never quite fitted the established categories: too Christian for the secular left, too political for the evangelical mainstream, too informal for the institutional church. What it represents, at its best, is the liberal Anglican tradition's most outward-facing expression: the stream of the tradition that believes the gospel has implications for poverty and empire and sexuality and the environment, and that being a Christian means following those implications wherever they lead, including onto uncomfortable ground. A day visit in August 2011 found a guided meditation using a mirror and a biscuit as props; a Methodist church art exhibition on Jesus in contemporary life; an Iona retreat tent; a Palestine solidarity stall; a pastor from the United States telling several thousand people that God had given Peter a second chance after he denied knowing Jesus three times, and that whatever they had failed at, the same offer stood. The politics and the theology and the folk music and the Christian Aid stall coexisted with the ease of people who have long since made their peace with the tradition's internal contradictions. Greenbelt is what Anglican festival Christianity looks like when

it decides to be generous rather than cautious: open to protest, comfortable with doubt, and mildly pleased with itself for being both. Standing at Canterbury one week and at Greenbelt the next, it is possible to see the full compass of what the Church of England contains, and to understand why both belong to the same tradition, even when they would barely recognise each other.

VI.

What the Anglican chaplaincy primarily shapes, looking back across years of Sunday evenings and house groups and carol services, is something like awareness: a quality of attentiveness to difficulty, to otherness, to the question that does not resolve. It does not produce the physical discipline of the UPC, the cognitive architecture of the LDS, or the imaginative richness of the Catholic retreat tradition. What it produces, at its best, is a particular posture toward uncertainty: not comfortable with it, not pretending it is not there, but willing to inhabit it without demanding its immediate resolution.

This posture has obvious limits. Awareness without commitment can become a form of permanent deferral, and the Church of England has sometimes made deferral into a way of life. A tradition that holds all questions open must eventually decide whether it holds any answers, and the Anglican answer

to that challenge has often been to hold the institution together by postponing the decision. The internal arguments about sexuality, about women in holy orders, about its relationship to other denominations, are not resolved by the chaplaincy's quality of welcome. They are deferred by it. The evangelicals outside Manchester Cathedral protesting the inclusion of Catholics were also Anglicans. The tradition that produced the Maundy Thursday Seder also produced them, and the chaplaincy's generous hospitality does not explain what the tradition intends to do about that fact.

But for a visitor who arrives with genuine questions and no settled conclusions, the chaplaincy offers something that very few of the other traditions encountered during these years are willing to offer: permission to stay in the question. Not permission to avoid commitment indefinitely, but permission to be, for now, honestly uncertain, and to be welcomed in that state rather than treated as a problem to be solved. The house groups cost one pound, include food cooked by someone who has thought about what you might like to eat, and ask you to write a chapter of Second John in your own language. The Christmas carol service is free if you helped organise it, two pounds if you did not, and the food afterwards is delicious. The Southport trip on the coach costs five pounds fifty. These are not small things. In a landscape of

demanding traditions, the chaplaincy's low-pressure welcome is itself a theological statement about what kind of God it believes in.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Church of Perfection

The Universal Pentecostal Church, Liverpool and Manchester

> *'God is rich in everything: mercy, forgiveness, wealth. We can become perfect in His grace.'*
>
> , A pastor's sermon, Burnage, August 2008

I.

The first thing a visitor notices is the sound. Before the door opens, before any face turns to acknowledge the newcomer, the sound arrives. It is not music in any conventional sense, not the organised swell of a hymn or the measured call-and-response of a liturgy. It is closer to a pressure, dozens of voices raised simultaneously, each in its own address to the same God, the cumulative noise rising and falling without coordination, a tide rather than a wave. Inside, people stand at their chairs with eyes closed and palms upturned, shouting praises to the Lord, some swaying, some utterly still. A few are speaking in tongues, syllables that follow the rhythm of intense speech but belong to no identifiable language. The room is a rented hall in a South Manchester suburb. The chairs are the kind used for community meetings and wedding receptions. On weekdays it belongs to someone else entirely.

This is the Universal Pentecostal Church, known in India and Sri Lanka as The Pentecostal Mission, in the United States as the New Testament Church, and in the United Kingdom by the name on the leaflet pressed into a visitor's hand at the door. The congregation here in Burnage meets on the third Monday of each month. The Sunday services are held in Liverpool, in a hall borrowed from a United Reformed Church in Liverpool, an arrangement whose quiet irony, a Calvinist space hosting a church that believes the Reformation did not go nearly far enough, seems to trouble no one. The pastors drive over from Liverpool. The faithful make the journey by car and train.

The church's origins are specific and largely unknown outside South Asian Christian communities. In 1923, a Kerala-born Hindu convert named Paul Ramankutty registered a small fellowship in Colombo, Sri Lanka, as the Ceylon Pentecostal Mission. Ramankutty, who took the name Pastor Paul, had converted at eighteen after, according to the church's own account, a vision of Jesus Christ. He built his movement around a doctrine that set it apart from the Pentecostal mainstream: salvation, in his teaching, was not the destination but only the beginning. The true goal was perfection, a state of holiness in which the believer had so thoroughly surrendered to God that sin could find no purchase. His pastors were to model this ideal. They were to be celibate, to live communally in faith homes, to relinquish private property, to exist, in essence, as monks, but monks who preached.

By the 1950s the church had reached Britain, carried initially by South Asian immigrants who had already encountered it in India or Sri Lanka. It grew quietly, without the visibility of the Caribbean-origin Pentecostal churches that came to define Britain's black majority church landscape. By 2013, Oneness Pentecostal bodies like this one represented only about four per cent of UK Pentecostal membership, against twenty-four per cent for the Redeemed Christian Church of God alone, which helps explain why a community of this depth and rigour could operate in a major city for decades with almost no wider visibility. Its congregation was, and remains, predominantly South Asian, nurses from Kerala, software engineers from Tamil Nadu, families who had come to cities like Manchester and Liverpool and found in this small, demanding community something that answered needs the surrounding culture could not.

II.

A Monday evening meeting in Burnage runs from seven until nine, and its structure is as regular as a timetable. The first hour is given almost entirely to praise. A visitor sits near the back and watches. People arrive in ones and twos, greet each other warmly, settle into chairs. Within minutes of the starting time, the pastor calls the meeting to order, not with an announcement, but by beginning to praise the Lord himself, loudly, and others join him, and within thirty seconds the room has transformed from a social gathering into something else entirely.

What strikes an observer immediately is the physicality of it. Pentecostalism is often described as emotionally intense, but this understates it. The emotion is housed in the body. People kneel on their chairs facing backwards, knees on the carpet, to pray. Hands are raised to specific heights, some chest-level, some above the head, and the variation seems meaningful though the meanings are not explained. When someone receives what seems to be a particular intensity of spiritual feeling, the shout of "Praise the Lord!" that breaks from them is involuntary, not performed. A visitor from a quieter tradition notices their own instinct to lower their voice, the way one lowers one's voice in a library, and then notices that the instinct is simply irrelevant here. The volume is the point.

Speaking in tongues, when it occurs, carries a different quality from the general praise. The surrounding voices soften. The tongues-speaker's voice takes on a fluency that sounds like genuine speech in an unknown language, not random sounds but structured utterance, with the rhythm of a sentence, the rise of a question, the fall of a declaration. Others listen without visible surprise. Occasionally someone offers a spoken interpretation in English. The congregation receives this as they would a scripture reading: attentively, then returning to their own prayer.

After an hour of this, the chairs are rearranged. A sister, the women who teach in this church carry that title as a matter of course, and they teach with full authority, begins the Bible study. On a typical evening the topic is the Acts of the Apostles, or a gospel, or Paul's letters. The teaching is systematic, verse by verse, occasionally

supplemented with a hand-drawn chart or a written list on the whiteboard. It is better prepared than many university lectures. The congregation follows in their own Bibles, making notes. Questions are welcomed. The learning here is earnest and thorough.

The visitor notices, watching all this, that the church functions as a total environment. The weekly schedule, Monday Bible study in Burnage, Wednesday prayer in Liverpool, Saturday's tarrying meeting, Sunday's main service, creates a structure that, if followed fully, accounts for most of a person's free evenings and one full day. Those who participate fully are not attending a church; they are inhabiting one. Their social world is largely contained within it. Their friendships are formed here. Their children attend Sunday school. When difficult things happen, illness, divorce, unemployment, grief, the community responds with practical support, with lifts and food and prayer and the reliable presence of people who already know the details of one's life.

III.

The theology of perfection deserves to be understood on its own terms, because it is easy to misread from the outside. Pastor Paul's founding doctrine held that salvation, the moment of genuine repentance and forgiveness, was real and necessary but insufficient. Beyond it lay a second stage: sanctification, the gradual purification of the believer's inner life until they could be said to be not merely forgiven but holy. The goal, in one pastor's formulation, was to be "not just saved but to achieve perfection." Christ himself had been

perfect in his humanity; the believer, indwelt by the Holy Spirit, was called to approximate that standard.

This sets the UPC apart from mainstream evangelical Protestantism in a significant way. Where most evangelical theology emphasises the complete sufficiency of grace, you are forgiven, and that is enough, the UPC adds a demanding ethical corollary. Being forgiven opens a door; walking through it requires continuous effort, continuous surrender, continuous watchfulness. The Christian life is not a settled condition but an ongoing project. The pastors who model it most fully are those who have renounced property and family, who live in the faith home and give their entire existence to God's service. They receive no regular income. They live by faith. They are, in the most precise sense of the word, monks.

The communion service illustrates the stakes of this theology. Bread and wine are distributed only to those who have been baptised by full immersion, in the prescribed trinitarian formula, administered by an ordained minister of this church specifically. Those baptised by sprinkling, as in most mainline Protestant and Catholic traditions, do not qualify. Those who have the salvation experience but have not yet received water baptism remain seated. Visitors, regardless of their own faith background, observe. There is no embarrassment in this, and no hostility. It is simply the order of things. The communion table is not a welcome extended to all Christians; it is a marker of achieved status within a specific spiritual journey.

The baptism class, when a visitor eventually attends one, clarifies the doctrinal stakes with a precision that is almost academic. The teacher is a sister with evident intellectual command of the material. She moves through the landscape of Christian traditions, identifying which practices she regards as biblically founded and which as later accretions. The infant sprinkling of baptism is an Old Testament rite imported into Christianity without scriptural mandate. Prayers to Mary and the veneration of saints are described as pagan elements absorbed during the church's long accommodation to Rome. The Jehovah's Witnesses and the Latter-day Saints are named as organisations that call themselves Christian but have departed from biblical truth in specified ways. Liberals who do not take scripture literally are characterised as people who have allowed their own preferences to override God's word. This is a tradition that knows exactly where it stands and has thought carefully about why.

What is striking is not the exclusivity, many traditions draw clear lines around their own practice, but the intellectual rigour with which those lines are drawn. These are not people who have inherited a position and not examined it. They have examined it, systematically, week after week, in Bible studies that track through the entire New Testament with scholarly attention to authorship, context, and internal consistency. The sister who teaches the gospels knows which details appear only in Luke, and why Luke's authorship matters, and what a physician's interest in miraculous healing would

mean for how he selected and framed his material. This is not a tradition that asks believers to switch off their minds.

IV.

The church's own history is carried in its testimonies. At almost every service, members stand to speak about what God has done in their lives. These are not vague expressions of gratitude. They are specific, often detailed accounts, a medical diagnosis that reversed unexpectedly, a family member who drifted from faith and returned, a financial crisis that resolved in ways the teller attributes to answered prayer. One woman describes a troubled life with the death of children and a divorce, followed by her husband's conversion, followed by a pregnancy that she says medical opinion had regarded as unlikely. She is composed while telling it. The congregation receives the account not as entertainment but as evidence.

The community's institutional history carries the same weight. A sister recounts how the church was founded in Sri Lanka, came to India, arrived in Britain in the 1950s through a single English believer who had been baptised in India and brought the faith home. In those early years, the pastors lived in cold rooms in south London, no central heating, icicles forming. They stayed because they had given everything. The church grew around their sacrifice. The implication, that sacrifice precedes growth, that the cold rooms and icicles were not obstacles to the church's expansion but conditions of it, is understood by everyone in the room.

The annual London convention in Brixton draws more than a thousand believers from across Britain for four days. There are ordinations, in which men and women are formally set apart for full-time ministry, cutting their links to private income and family independence. There are baptisms performed in a pool, each preceded by an interview with the elders to confirm that the candidate genuinely understands what is being undertaken. During the baptisms there is singing and shouting and speaking in tongues. The pastors who conduct the ceremony do so with the authority of those who have themselves passed through it and then given decades to its implications.

At the revival meetings, held in rented school halls in Liverpool over three days, with an early-morning prayer meeting at seven and an evening service that must vacate the premises by ten, the tone shifts slightly. These are also evangelistic events. The speaker addresses those who have not yet committed, or who have committed and drifted. The message is urgent without being threatening. God does not hate you. God is not angry with you. On the contrary, he loves you, and has already paid the cost of your forgiveness. All that remains is to accept it, and then to begin the longer work of perfection. The door is open. But it must be walked through entirely.

V.

The question this community poses most sharply is what it means for a tradition to shape the body. The UPC does not merely teach

doctrines; it organises physical experience. The body kneels. The voice shouts. The hands rise. The tongue speaks syllables it has not learned. The weekly schedule creates a rhythm in which the body knows, by the day of the week, what kind of activity it is about to perform. This is not the cognitive shaping of the Mormons, who structure the mind through systematic study and an integrated worldview. It is something more visceral than that.

A visitor who spends months attending these meetings observes something interesting in their own responses. The praise sessions, which initially seemed uncomfortable in their volume and emotional directness, gradually become navigable. The body learns to be in the room without resistance. The shouting ceases to be surprising. More significantly, something in the collective state, the density of focused attention, the shared orientation toward a single invisible presence, begins to carry its own weight. This is not conversion, or anything approaching it. But it is evidence that the tradition is doing something. The practices are not merely expressive; they are formative.

The theology of the body that underpins this practice has been worked out carefully. The body is a tabernacle: the outer court is visible behaviour, the holy place is the mind, the innermost sanctuary is the spirit. The spiritual journey moves inward through these concentric spaces. Baptism is burial and resurrection in the body; speaking in tongues is the Holy Spirit animating the body's own voice; the communion service, restricted to those who are clean in their conscience, is the body receiving what only a purified spirit

can receive. The physical disciplines, fasting, kneeling, the rules about jewellery and alcohol that mark the serious believer from the casual one, are not add-ons to a primarily cognitive faith. They are the faith, enacted in flesh.

The question the visitor eventually has to answer for themselves is whether this formative power is available to them, and what entering it would require. The answer turns out to be more complicated than a simple yes or no. The warmth of the community is genuine and unperformed. The intellectual seriousness is real. The theological coherence is impressive. The people who have given their lives to this tradition, the pastors who sleep in the faith home, the sisters who have taught the same congregation through the same texts for years, the brothers who drive across from Liverpool every third Monday and stay to help stack the chairs and distribute the samosas and the coffee, these are not people who have been deceived or coerced. They have made a considered choice, and they carry it with a lightness that suggests it has rewarded them.

What the tradition asks in return is complete. Not merely attendance, or assent, or the adoption of certain practices. It asks for surrender, of private doctrinal judgment, of the comfortable distance a seeker maintains between themselves and commitment. The communion that can only be administered by two qualified pastors in the entire country; the baptism that must be performed by a minister with proper authority in the proper trinitarian form; the theology that draws precise lines around which expressions of Christianity are biblical and which are accretions: all of this

constitutes a system that is internally consistent and externally bounded. You can observe it from outside with respect and even admiration. Entry, however, is not a matter of degrees. And remaining outside, the visitor discovers, has its own costs. Three years of Monday evenings without water baptism is not a neutral position within this community. It is a standing refusal of what the community believes is urgently necessary. The warmth of the welcome never wavers. But the warmth is not indifference to the refusal. It is, rather, the community's way of continuing to hold the door open. The visitor who stays outside long enough comes to understand that the door is being held open specifically for him, and that this is both generous and a form of sustained pressure.

VI.

On a summer evening in 2011, a visitor tells the brothers that he will be leaving soon, returning to India. A brother, one of those who has been gently encouraging water baptism for some time, says simply: come to Liverpool before you go. It is an invitation, not a reproach. The conversation lasts less than a minute. Then the chairs are stacked, the instruments packed into their cases, and the brothers carry everything out to the car park in the Manchester evening.

What the visitor carries away is not what the tradition hoped to leave with them. No baptism has taken place. No formal commitment has been made. But something about the three years of Monday evenings has left a residue that is harder to name than doctrine. It is something about the seriousness with which these

people treat the question of how to live. About the refusal to treat faith as a background condition rather than a total claim. About what it looks like when a community actually believes that the things it says it believes are true, and organises its entire embodied life around that belief, week after week, in a rented hall in a South Manchester suburb, across the road from a chip shop, with samosas at the end.

Most traditions encountered in these years made some accommodation to the surrounding culture, softened a claim here, widened a welcome there, left space for doubt. The UPC did not. It is possible to regard this as rigidity. It is also possible to regard it, as the church regards itself, as faithfulness. The doctrine of perfection holds that salvation is not the end of the story but the beginning of a longer and harder one. Whether or not that doctrine is true, it produces people who are, by any observable measure, serious. In a landscape of easy commitments and provisional affiliations, that seriousness is, at minimum, worth attending to.

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CHAPTER FIVE

The Missionaries at the Door

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, Manchester

> *'The only way to know if the Book of Mormon is true is to notice the feelings, the peace, the joy, the inspiration to do something right away.'*
>
> , An elder, during a home meeting, November 2007

I.

They are easy to spot. Two young men in white shirts and dark ties, name badges pinned to the left breast, walking with a purposefulness that belongs to neither students nor office workers. They move through the city in pairs, always in pairs, because the rules require it. They are typically American, typically from Utah or Idaho, typically in their late teens or early twenties. They have come here on a two-year assignment, largely at their own family's expense, during which they will not watch films or television, will not date, will limit their contact with family to weekly emails and occasional phone calls. They will walk, knock, teach, pray, and invite. They are the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints' most visible presence in cities like Manchester, and they understand this.

The Manchester Stake, as it happens, carries particular weight in the church's own history. Organised in 1960 at the Manchester Hippodrome, a meeting whose opening hymn rang out weeks after the Beatles failed an audition in the same building, it was the first LDS stake established outside North America. By the time the missionaries who would be encountered here were walking the streets of Fallowfield and Hulme, England had more Latter-day Saint members than any other country in Europe: around 145,000 registered by 2011. The church had been in northern England for nearly 170 years, its first English baptisms performed in the River Ribble at Preston in 1837. This is not a newcomer faith here. It has had time to build something settled, something institutional, something confident in its welcome.

The encounter that begins this chapter starts at a Thursday evening gathering for young single adults, volleyball and cookies in a chapel in Wythenshawe, followed by the first of what will become a long series of home meetings at the flat of a local member, a quiet, warm man who organises these encounters with the care of someone who finds it genuinely important. There are two elders present. They begin with a prayer. They ask questions first, not to assess but to open: What do you believe about God? What do you think happens

after death? The questions are not rhetorical. They listen carefully to the answers. Then, gradually, they begin to teach.

II.

The missionary discussions, now codified in a manual called "Preach My Gospel", introduced by the church in 2004, follow a careful sequence. The first lesson concerns the Restoration: the claim that Christianity fell into apostasy after the deaths of the original apostles, that divine authority was lost from the earth for roughly seventeen centuries, and that it was restored through Joseph Smith, a young man in upstate New York who, in 1820, prayed for guidance in a grove of trees and received a vision of God the Father and Jesus Christ as two distinct, embodied persons. The gold plates from which Smith translated the Book of Mormon were delivered to him by an angel. The authority to baptise and confer the Holy Spirit was restored through angelic visitation. The church founded in 1830 is not, therefore, a new religion. It is the original one, returned.

This framing is important for understanding the experience of being taught by the elders. The claim they make is not simply that their church is better than others, or that its moral code is preferable, or that its community life is richer. The claim is ontological: that the authority to perform saving

ordinances, baptism, the conferral of the Holy Spirit, the sealing of families for eternity, does not exist anywhere else on earth. Other churches may be sincere and may do genuine good. But they lack priesthood authority, the genuine power to act in God's name. This is not mentioned aggressively. It is mentioned with the gentleness of people explaining something they regard as factually true and urgently important for the person across from them to understand.

The readings assigned between meetings follow the same logic of sequence. The investigator, the church's term for someone receiving the lessons, is asked to read specific chapters of the Book of Mormon and then to pray about whether they are true. The prayer is not asked to be open-ended. The elders are specific about what to attend to: not arguments, not historical evidence, but feelings. If the reading produces peace, warmth, a sense of being in the presence of something good, that is the Holy Spirit confirming the book's truth. The mechanism is explicit and consistent. The elders themselves have felt it. They know the book is true not because they have proved it but because they have prayed and felt the answer. It is worth pausing here, because this epistemology has a specific shape. It is not irrational, but it is systematically protected against rational challenge: any argument against the Book of Mormon's truth can be reframed as a failure to pray

with sufficient sincerity. The system knows this and does not apologise for it. The Holy Spirit, not historical scholarship, is the court of final appeal. This makes the missionary discussions genuinely difficult to engage with as an investigator who takes both feelings and arguments seriously, because the framework has already decided which counts.

Sitting with this epistemology across many months of meetings, a visitor finds it both internally coherent and resistant to conventional challenge. One cannot argue against a felt experience. The elders have been trained in this: when a question arises that seems to undermine the historical or archaeological claims of the church, the response is gentle redirection toward the subjective. Have you read the chapter? Have you prayed about it? What did you feel? The feeling is the evidence. The feeling is not merely a feeling; it is, in the church's account, communication from God.

III.

What is striking, across these encounters, is the elders' genuineness. They are not salespeople performing a pitch. They believe what they are saying with an earnestness that is not easily faked across months of regular contact. One of the elders, who is present at most of the early meetings, speaks of his faith with the straightforwardness of someone for whom it

is simply the operating framework of reality. He is kind and patient with questions, even the same question asked in different ways. He will sing, two-part harmonies with his companion, a Christmas carol unrehearsed and beautiful, without self-consciousness. He has had rocks thrown at him while knocking on doors. He has learned to ignore this in what he calls the spirit of amiability. He will be here for two years and then go home and resume his life. He understands this is a gift he is giving, not a career.

The home meetings themselves have a social texture that is easy to underestimate. The local member who hosts them prepares food, always good food, Texan chocolate cake one evening, a proper dinner another. His warmth is ungauged and unsentimental. He asks about work, about the week, about how things are going. The church's larger social calendar is extended with quiet insistence: Monday family home evening, Thursday institute at Wythenshawe, Friday dances, Sunday sacrament meeting. The investigator is not merely being taught a doctrine; they are being gently inserted into a community. Each event attended thickens the web. By the time baptism is mentioned for the first time, the investigator already has friends here. Already knows which elder tells the better stories. Already knows where the volleyball court is.

The chapter on family is particularly telling. LDS theology holds that the family unit is not merely a temporal arrangement but an eternal one: a marriage sealed in the temple binds husband and wife, and their children, across death. The family home evening, a weekly Monday gathering at which Mormon families spend dedicated time together, studying scripture, playing games, eating, is a ritual embodiment of this belief. The doctrine produces a distinctive social atmosphere. At the Thursday institute evening, the young adults are mainly American; many are on missions or have returned from them. They are cheerful, socially confident, and carry the particular ease of people who know who they are and what they believe. There is no ambient nihilism here, no performative irony. The visitor from outside notices its absence.

IV.

The church's cognitive architecture, its way of organising the mind, is the most analytically interesting thing about it. The Latter-day Saint tradition does not merely offer beliefs; it offers a complete and interlocking system in which every question has an answer located within the system, and the system's truth has been confirmed by a feeling whose validity the system has taught the believer to recognise. The plan of salvation, the church's account of pre-mortal existence in God's kingdom,

earthly probation, death, judgment, and eternal progression through multiple kingdoms of glory, is not a collection of vague spiritual gestures. It is a detailed, mapped cosmology with specific doctrines about why suffering exists (the fall of Adam was necessary for moral knowledge), why God permits inequality (individual circumstances are spiritually tailored), and what happens to those who died before hearing the gospel (proxy baptism can be performed for them by living relatives in the temple).

The meetings return again and again to a set of specific texts, Ether 12, Alma 36, 1 Nephi, Moroni 10, and a set of specific intellectual problems: why do people suffer? why do some suffer more than others? what is the relationship between faith and proof? The elders engage these questions seriously. The answers they give are consistent with the system: God knew about Adam's fall and permitted it because without it humanity could not have moral freedom; the apparent inequality of suffering in the world reflects individual spiritual circumstances that God, who is omniscient, understands even when we cannot. These are not dismissals of the questions. They are answers. The system has thought about this.

What the repeated structure of the meetings gradually reveals is that the thinking has already been done. Each week the investigator brings their questions, and each week the

questions receive careful, patient, systematically prepared responses. The elders have been trained, at the Preston England Temple's missionary training centre, just off the M61, where they spent weeks learning to read carefully and teach plainly, to field questions without being destabilised by them. The system they represent is sufficiently comprehensive that almost any objection can be located within it and resolved. The experience of intellectual engagement with the elders is not the experience of open inquiry. It is the experience of being led, with great patience and warmth, toward conclusions that were settled before the conversation began.

The Sunday sacrament meeting at the Stretford Ward adds another layer. Two thousand people fill the Wythenshawe stake centre for the regional conference, many with children and young families. The choir is near-professional. The talks are given not by clergy, the LDS church has no paid professional ministry at the local level, but by ordinary members, lay people who have prepared carefully and speak with evident conviction. One elder, one of the seventy, gives a talk on happiness: it is a condition of inner orientation, not external circumstance; God is of a cheerful countenance; severe challenges are events in a life, not the life itself. He mentions the dangers of scepticism. The audience receives this

without visible discomfort. It is a room of people who have decided.

V.

The conversion process, seen from the outside, has an engineering quality that it would be wrong to call cynical. The church genuinely believes it is offering something urgently necessary. But the process is designed with a care that leaves little to chance. The reading assignments build on each other. The social invitations surround the doctrine. The emotional evidence, the felt confirmation of the Book of Mormon's truth, is both the goal of the process and the criterion by which its success is measured. A structured timetable is offered for daily reading. The elders guarantee that if the investigator reads and prays for the recommended time each day, they will feel more refreshed, not less. The commitment requested grows in small increments: come to one meeting; attend one Sunday service; attend every Sunday service; consider baptism.

At a baptism attended at the stake centre, the pool is large and purpose-built. The candidate has been interviewed by the elders beforehand, his beliefs and repentance confirmed. The service in the adjacent room before the baptism is brief and warm. The baptism itself takes seconds. Afterwards there is chocolate and banana cake. The elders explain the four steps:

repentance, baptism, the laying on of hands to receive the Holy Ghost, and enduring to the end. The laying on of hands, performed by those with proper priesthood authority, is described as God's response to the commitment made through his authorised servants. It is not a separate thing from baptism but its complement. The two together open the door. Then comes the lifelong work of renewing the covenant each Sunday through the sacrament.

One detail sticks. Baptism can be performed by proxy, in the temple, on behalf of those who have died without hearing the gospel. The church maintains the largest genealogical database in the world partly for this reason: every ancestor who can be identified can potentially be given the ordinance by a living descendant. Death is not the end of the opportunity. The reach of the system, in this doctrine, extends not only into the future but backward through all of human history. It is a cosmology without loose ends.

VI.

The meetings continue through the winter and into spring. The questions become more specific as the investigator reads more carefully. Why did the ancient Israelites sail to the Americas? The elders offer archaeological suggestions and redirect toward feeling. What is the evidence for the Great Apostasy, the claim

that true Christianity vanished entirely for seventeen centuries? The elders acknowledge the difficulty and note that the very existence of hundreds of competing denominations, each claiming authority, is itself evidence that something was lost. These are not non-answers. They are the system's best responses. But they require a prior commitment to the system to be fully satisfying, and that prior commitment is precisely what is being sought.

The word of wisdom, the prohibition on tea, coffee, alcohol, and tobacco, becomes a point of extended conversation. The elders frame it as a law of health given through revelation, a gift rather than a restriction. They acknowledge the difficulty of giving up tea, which is not a small thing in English life, and suggest praying for help. They note that giving something up for God tends to produce a return: more energy, more clarity, a feeling of being cared for. The epistemology here is the same as it is everywhere else in the system. The experience of obedience is its own confirmation.

By late spring, the meetings are still happening but something has shifted. The investigator has read widely in the Book of Mormon. They have attended Sunday services, stake conferences, a baptism, a general conference broadcast from Salt Lake City where the Mormon Tabernacle Choir sings and the apostles speak from a stage in Utah while two thousand

people in Wythenshawe watch on a screen. They have played volleyball and eaten cake and been asked about their week and felt, genuinely, the warmth of a community that has decided they matter. But the felt confirmation, the peace, the warmth, the certainty the elders described, has not arrived in the form the system requires. Or perhaps it has arrived in a form too ambiguous to stake one's entire worldview on.

VII.

The Mormon tradition primarily shapes the mind. Not in a reductive or dismissive sense. The mind it shapes is genuinely engaged, genuinely stretched. The questions it asks of an investigator are real questions: who are you, where did you come from, where are you going, why does suffering exist, what does it mean to be a family? These are not trivial questions dressed up in jargon. They are the questions that matter most, taken with full seriousness.

What the tradition offers in answer to these questions is a system whose completeness is both its great strength and, for some, its obstacle. The strength is clarity: in the LDS account, there are no loose ends, no unresolvable mysteries, no permanent ambiguities. The cosmology extends from pre-mortal existence to eternal progression. The authority is traceable through an unbroken chain to heaven itself. The

family is sealed forever. The dead can still be reached. Every question the investigator brings has, within the system, an answer.

The obstacle, for those who encounter it from outside, is the totalising quality of that clarity. To accept the system fully is to accept that every other tradition, however sincere, however good, lacks the authority to perform saving ordinances. It is to accept that the felt warmth of reading the Book of Mormon is, specifically, the Holy Spirit's confirmation of Joseph Smith's prophetic role. It is to accept that the church's current president is a living prophet whose counsel carries divine weight. These are not small things to accept. The elders understand this and say so, gently and repeatedly. They do not minimise the cost. They simply believe the reward exceeds it.

On a Sunday morning in spring, a visitor attends what turns out to be one of the last sacrament meetings before the elder rotations change the names on the badges. After the service, the elder says goodbye with a warmth that is unmistakably genuine. He hopes the investigation will continue. He expresses, without pressure, his confidence that the answer will come. The phrase "without pressure" deserves a moment's attention. It is accurate: no pressure is applied, no urgency deployed, no disappointment shown. But the

confidence itself is a kind of pressure, quiet and structural. It assumes that the investigation has a correct conclusion, that the visitor will reach it if he prays correctly, and that the elder already knows what it is. The warmth and the certainty are not separable. Then he goes to prepare for the next appointment. He has perhaps a year left of his two years. He will go home and be a person who did this, who walked through northern English cities in a white shirt in the rain, who had rocks thrown at him, who sang in harmony unrehearsed in a stranger's sitting room, who believed all of it completely and gave two years to saying so. Whatever the visitor thinks of the theology, there is something in this that commands a plain respect.

CHAPTER SIX

The Retreat and the Tradition

The Roman Catholic Church: Jesuits, Opus Dei, and the Parish

> *'With enhanced mindfulness of being alive, the moment I turned my attention God was always there.'*
>
> , Personal notes, closing day of the Loyola House Jesuit retreat, March 2008

I.

The Catholic Church presents itself to a visitor not as a single community but as a civilisation, one old enough to contain within it several distinct schools of thought, several distinct temperaments, several distinct ways of being serious about God. Other traditions encountered in these years are, by comparison, relatively unified: the UPC has its specific doctrinal programme, the LDS its structured lessons, the Anglicans their broad-church consensus. Catholicism has all of these and more, including two centuries of argument about which of them is most faithful to the original. To engage with it seriously is to find that you are not engaging with one thing but with several, each with its own history, its own saints, its own characteristic way of forming the interior life.

In Manchester across the years of the visitor's stay, three strands of this civilisation are encountered with enough depth to be

worth describing separately. The first is the Jesuit strand, the tradition of Ignatius of Loyola, his Spiritual Exercises, the particular method of prayer and self-examination his order has practised and transmitted for nearly five centuries. The second is Opus Dei, the personal prelature of the Catholic Church founded in Madrid in 1928 by the priest Josemaria Escriva, canonised in 2002, whose spirituality centres on finding God in the sanctification of ordinary work and whose institutional presence in Manchester includes a student hall of residence and a rural retreat house. The third is the mainstream parish, Holy Name church on Oxford Road, the university chaplaincy, the carol services and Easter vigils and baptisms that form the rhythm of Catholic life for those who practise it without particular allegiance to any internal school.

These three are not in conflict. They inhabit the same Church, attend the same Mass, hold the same creedal positions. But they produce noticeably different experiences, and they shape the imagination in different ways. The Jesuit approach opens inward and asks questions. The Opus Dei approach organises outward and gives answers. The parish absorbs both into its own long rhythm, which predates both and will outlast both.

II.

The Loyola House retreat is introduced to a visitor in the early months of 2008. The retreat director, who runs it, is from Loyola House, a Jesuit centre that offers, among other things, a retreat in daily life: a programme in which the director comes to the retreatant

rather than the retreatant withdrawing from the world entirely, because the world, in the Ignatian view, is precisely where God is to be found and should not be fled. The week-long intensive version offered here asks for one thing above all: thirty minutes of daily prayer, at whatever time of day the mind is freshest, and a short meeting with the spiritual director each day to reflect on what emerged.

The method is Lectio Divina, take a passage of scripture, sit with it, let words or phrases that seem alive speak to you, and imaginative contemplation: place yourself in a gospel scene, not as a detached observer but as a participant, and let your imagination go where it will. What did you see, hear, smell? Which figure did you identify with? Where did the scene lead when you stopped controlling it? The director, meeting daily for fifteen to thirty minutes, does not evaluate the content of what emerges. He asks what feelings arose and suggests that the feelings, warmth, discomfort, peace, resistance, are themselves information. They are not embellishments to the prayer. They are the prayer's substance.

The specific contemplation assigned on one day is the Transfiguration: Mark 9, verses 2 to 8, in which Jesus is transformed on a mountaintop before three disciples, his clothes becoming radiantly white, a voice from a cloud declaring him the beloved Son. The instruction is to enter the scene and let the imagination take it wherever it leads. What is reported back to the director need not match the text closely. If the imagination travels somewhere

unexpected, that is not error. It may be exactly where it was supposed to go.

The workshop on images of God is characteristic of the method's spirit. The director plays a Simpsons episode in which Homer refuses to attend church, God appears to him in a dream and is unexpectedly relaxed about it, and Homer decides to start his own religion. He shows a slideshow of images of God: medieval icons, a father-and-son embrace on a beach, a beer party, the earth from space, a blank slide representing darkness, a cartoon of God at a computer pressing a drop button as a piano falls on someone below. The question asked of the group is which images resonate, which disturb, and what those reactions reveal about the image of God each person has carried, often without knowing it, since childhood. The method trusts that what happens in the imagination is real, not as good as reality, not a substitute for reality, but real in its own register. The feelings are the evidence.

On the closing day of the retreat, reflecting on the week in a small group, something is said that is worth recording. In the twenty minutes of silent contemplation that opens the session, there is a felt sense, difficult to characterise more precisely than this, of heightened attention to the fact of being alive: the sounds of the room, the weight of hands resting on a table, the particular quality of morning light. The moment one's attention turned toward God, in whatever direction that turning pointed, something was already there. This is not a conversion experience. It does not settle any theological question. But it is a genuine experience of a kind that the

Ignatian method was specifically designed to produce, and its production in a person who approached the retreat with considerable scepticism says something about the method's skill.

III.

The Opus Dei student residence in Manchester is a Victorian terrace converted under the inspiration of Josemaria Escriva. It houses nineteen male students, is open to men of all backgrounds and faiths, and runs a programme of seminars, sports, and spiritual activities alongside its residential function. An oratory on the premises offers daily Mass. It is an Opus Dei corporate undertaking, and this is not concealed. The connection is explained straightforwardly to visitors, along with the basics of what Opus Dei is: a personal prelature of the Catholic Church whose specific mission is to help ordinary men and women seek holiness in their everyday work and family life, not in monasteries or religious houses but in offices and kitchens and university labs.

The Benediction of the Blessed Sacrament at the residence, an evening service of adoration in which the consecrated Host is exposed in a monstrance and the congregation prays before it, is conducted with careful formality. The Latin hymns are sung from memory: O Salutaris Hostia, Tantum Ergo Sacramentum, the Salve Regina. The meditation given by the resident priest draws on TS Eliot's quotation of Dante, "In His will is our peace", which Eliot called the profoundest line in human literature, and on the writings of Escriva, who taught that the best way to live one's life was to

understand that God made us and left instructions, just as an appliance comes with a maker's manual, and that following those instructions was not a constraint but the path to our own deepest flourishing. The comparison is not demeaning. It is offered with genuine conviction.

The carol service at the residence in December draws students and professionals, about thirty to forty people. The music is good, accompanied on piano, the carols arranged so that men and women sing alternating verses, or the room divides into groups to sing different stanzas, producing, unexpectedly, a genuine choir effect from untrained voices. Wine and mince pies are served before and during. The atmosphere is warm, self-contained, intellectually confident. People here are not anxious about their faith. They are not working through doubts. They have a clear picture of what they believe and why, and they carry it without effort.

IV.

The weekend retreat departs from the residence on a Friday evening: a small group of six, a retreat director, and a priest, travelling by car to a former family manor in rural Cheshire, about an hour from Manchester. The hall itself has the feel of a house that has been used for this purpose long enough that the purpose has become its natural state: quiet corridors, a chapel, a library, a dining room where meals appear at regular intervals. The retreatants are allocated rooms. Jobs are assigned: who will do the spiritual reading at mealtimes, who will

raise the blinds in the morning. Silence is observed except during designated periods. It is a silent retreat.

The schedule is tightly structured from the first evening. The meditations follow a progression: the purpose of life, the nature of original sin, the Incarnation understood as God's radical self-lowering, the Stations of the Cross, the sanctification of work. The texts drawn on are Escriva's "The Way of the Cross" and his homilies, John Paul II's "Crossing the Threshold of Hope," the life of Karol Wojtyla in Polish underground resistance. Each meditation ends with an intercession to the Virgin Mary, asked to help with whatever the meditation has surfaced. The Rosary is prayed in the evening, fifty Hail Marys in full, in alternating call and response. The examination of conscience is performed three times daily: morning, afternoon, before bed. Is it right or wrong? Right direction? How was my day? Am I closer to heaven or one step back?

Compared to the Loyola House retreat, the structural difference is immediate and significant. The Ignatian method opens space and waits to see what occupies it. The Opus Dei method fills the space with content and asks the retreatant to receive and apply it. The Ignatian approach treats the interior life as territory to be explored under guidance, with the retreatant's own imagination and feelings as primary data. The Opus Dei approach treats the interior life as territory to be ordered according to a map that has already been drawn. The exploration is real, but its coordinates are fixed in advance.

This is not a criticism. The map is a good one, worked out over decades of careful thought about how to live well in the world without withdrawing from it. The meditation on sanctifying work, that everything done in one's job, done well and for God's glory, is itself a form of prayer, is one of the more practically useful ideas encountered in any tradition during these years. The instruction to consider whether one's work is ethical, to serve tea at work with a smile, to think how to improve the lives of colleagues, not in grand gestures but in small changes that ripple outward, this is concrete, applicable, and grounded in a theology of ordinary life that many more dramatic religious programmes entirely lack.

What requires more careful attention is the place of the will in all this. The meditation on the two wills, the superior rational will oriented toward God, and the inferior sensual will oriented toward appetite and comfort, teaches that the daily struggle is to ensure the rational will prevails. The method for achieving this is self-denial: fasting, renouncing small pleasures, not being too ambitious, refusing to do work with a lukewarm spirit. Violence to the ego self, in Escriva's formulation, is necessary for the capacity to do God's will when one recognises it. The language is demanding in a way the Ignatian language is not. Where the Ignatian method asks what you feel and treats the answer as sacred, the Opus Dei method asks what you want and begins with the assumption that what you want is probably part of the problem.

V.

The parish, against these two demanding interior traditions, seems at first to offer less. The carol service at Holy Name on Oxford Road, bishop in procession, university choirs, everyone holding a lit candle, the singing of things that have been sung in this room for a long time, does not ask for the kind of attention either retreat required. The Easter midnight vigil, the church packed with students and families, candles lit, vows of baptism renewed in unison, holy water sprinkled across the crowd, the procession out into the Manchester night: these are experiences of beauty and communal belonging, not of individual interior examination.

Yet the parish carries something the retreats do not, precisely because it does not demand individual examination. The Feast of Pentecost mass at Holy Name includes a baptism: four adults, completing a year of preparation, come forward to be received into the Church. The priest, addressing them, mentions that technically, at this moment, their sins having been forgiven, each of them is a saint. He wonders aloud whether, fifty years from now, they might remember the priest who baptised them. The remark is light, even slightly comic in its self-awareness, and then immediately it is not comic at all, because the occasion it is attached to is completely serious. In fifty years these four people will either be alive or dead, and the question of what will have mattered in the intervening time is not a trivial one.

The apologetics seminars at the Catholic chaplaincy, a series of talks open to anyone, covering the Bible, prayer, Mary, the saints, represent a third mode: the tradition in argument with questions

rather than either opening them contemplatively or resolving them by authority. Felix, who leads the seminar on the Bible, is intellectually honest about the disputed canon: Protestant rejection of the deuterocanonical books was a historical and political choice, not a neutral reading of scriptural evidence, and the Catholic acceptance of those books has its own logic. The question of whether the Bible is true as history is distinguished carefully from the question of whether it is true as testimony of faith, a distinction that many simpler traditions collapse but that Catholic thought has learned, over centuries of argument, to hold open. We can take historical research seriously and still find the texts infinitely richer when read with faith. This is not evasion. It is, in its way, a sophisticated position.

VI.

What the Catholic tradition shapes, above all, is the imagination. Not imagination in the trivial sense of fantasy or daydream, but in the theological sense that the Jesuits formalised: the capacity to inhabit a scene, a narrative, a symbolic world so fully that it begins to work on the person inhabiting it. The Ignatian retreatant who enters the Transfiguration and finds that their imagination goes somewhere unexpected is being formed by that experience whether or not they can explain what happened. The retreatant who meditates daily on the Incarnation, God choosing to be born among the poorest of the poor, in a manger, in Bethlehem, so cold that night, is having their picture of the world altered by repeated contemplation of a particular

image. The person who stands in Holy Name holding a candle while a choir sings something ancient and complicated is being touched by something that exceeds their capacity to analyse it in real time.

What distinguishes the Catholic approach to imagination from that of other traditions is the density and age of its symbolic vocabulary. The saints, the liturgical calendar, the sacramental system, the Marian tradition, the imagery of crucifixion and resurrection and glorification, these are not merely theological propositions illustrated with pictures. They are a carefully developed language for talking about things that resist direct statement, refined over two millennia of use by people who found them genuinely adequate to their experience. A visitor who does not share the faith can still find that the language does something. Standing before a side-chapel of Westminster Cathedral, Byzantine brick, the mosaics half-finished above the arches, the peculiar quality of light, something in the visual grammar of the space communicates more than its propositional content. It is not necessary to believe in what the space was built for in order to be affected by the seriousness with which it was built.

The Jesuit and Opus Dei retreats, taken together, reveal a tradition that has thought with exceptional care about what happens in the interior life and how it can be directed. Their methods differ significantly, one opens, the other structures, but both proceed from the conviction that the interior life is real, that it matters enormously, and that it does not develop well without intentional cultivation. This is a conviction not widely shared in the surrounding secular culture,

which tends to treat the interior life as either a matter of individual taste or a subject for therapeutic management. The Catholic tradition has a different view: that the interior life is the site where the most important things happen, that it has a direction, and that getting that direction right is the central task of a human life.

A visitor who came to these communities sceptical and left still sceptical is nonetheless left with something. The felt sense of God's presence during the Loyola House meditation, that heightened attentiveness, the sense that the moment one turned toward something it was already there, did not resolve into a belief. But it was real. Whatever it was, it was real. That is perhaps what the Catholic tradition, at its best, most reliably produces in anyone who engages with it seriously: not certainty, which it can offer to those who accept its premises, but an irreversible expansion of the question.

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CHAPTER SEVEN

The Rational Faith

Evangelical Christianity: the Alpha course, the student union, and the large church

> *'Just saying he was a good man is patronising nonsense. He had to be either completely crazy or correct.'*
>
> , Alpha course lecture, Manchester, 2010

I.

Evangelical Christianity makes an argument. This is its defining characteristic, the thing that most clearly distinguishes it from the other traditions described in this book. The UPC asks you to feel the body's surrender. The Catholic retreat asks you to let your imagination be formed by centuries of symbol and narrative. The Anglican chaplaincy holds the question open and trusts that something will eventually inhabit it. Evangelical Christianity does something different: it presents a case, marshals evidence, anticipates objections, and invites you to reach a conclusion. The conclusion is specified in advance. But the route to it is, at least in aspiration, rational.

This matters because it produces a distinctive kind of encounter. Where other traditions tend to receive the visitor in

a register that is primarily aesthetic or communal or interior, the evangelical encounter tends to be intellectual, or at least to frame itself that way. A visiting preacher at the university Christian Union opens his talk on the resurrection not with a call to prayer or a moment of silence but with the testimony of a Roman historian and a first-century Jewish writer: two non-Christian sources who confirm, he argues, that Jesus of Nazareth was crucified and that his followers claimed to have seen him alive afterwards. The argument is then built outward from this historical base: the physical facts of death by crucifixion, the medical evidence from the account of a soldier's spear, the inexplicability of the empty tomb on any theory that does not involve resurrection. Come to your own conclusion. But here is the evidence.

The Alpha course, which circulates through several venues during these years, once at a Methodist church in a small group of eight, later at the university chaplaincy with Taiwanese students, operates on the same principle scaled up and packaged for a mass audience. The course was developed at a large London church and has been used in communities worldwide; its author, a barrister turned clergyman, brings a lawyer's instinct for structured argument to questions of faith. Each session presents a talk, originally delivered to a live audience and circulated on DVD, followed by discussion. The

first session's topic: was Jesus boring, untrue, or irrelevant? The argument proceeds through historical sources, philosophical analysis of the options available if one accepts that Jesus made the claims attributed to him, and medical detail about what crucifixion does to a body. It is thorough. It is prepared. It is, in its way, impressive.

II.

The university Christian Union is the institutional expression of this argumentative confidence in a student setting. It is part of a national network of student evangelical organisations affiliated to a central body whose specific mission is gospel proclamation on university campuses. At its regular meetings, held in whatever room is available, usually in an evening, always with food beforehand, the questions put into the box by the audience are answered by a panel of student members speaking from their own experience and from scripture. The questions do not avoid difficulty: why does the Old Testament God seem different from the New Testament God? Why does Christianity reject Islam? How can God be three and one simultaneously? The answers engage with the questions seriously. They do not always satisfy, but they are given with evident thought.

What is notable about the CU environment is the warmth of its welcome alongside the clarity of its doctrinal position. These are not qualities that always coexist. The two students who speak to a visitor at length after a meeting, clarifying what the original Greek of the New Testament actually says, explaining what distinguishes a Christian from someone who merely attends church, distinguishing carefully between baptism as a symbol and baptism as an essential doctrine (it is the former, they say), do so with a genuine desire to be understood rather than to recruit. The conversation runs for a long time. It is the sort of conversation that is possible only between people who both take the subject seriously.

The CU mission week brings a visiting preacher who has spent his career addressing student audiences on questions of faith. He is warm, self-deprecating, full of stories about Yorkshire, and entirely clear about what he believes. His talk on sin opens with the observation that every morning in front of a mirror we should notice what astonishing creatures we are, and then confront what we do with that. He moves through Mark's gospel cataloguing what Jesus himself said human beings are capable of. The price of all of it, he says, has already been paid. The only remaining question is whether you will accept the payment on your behalf. At the end he makes

himself available to talk to anyone who wishes to become a Christian. Several people do.

A separate CU event presents an enactment of Mark's gospel by seven student members performing in the round, with the audience seated in a circle. Seven actors take all the roles, the Pharisees, Herod, the disciples, the people healed, the people who fail to understand. The enactment is faithful to the text but vivid and physical; during the multiplication of loaves, the audience participates, passing bread between themselves and collecting the leftovers in baskets. The event has a conservative theological slant, there are moments where the text is rendered more literally than a liberal reading would require, but it is also genuinely theatrical, and the theatrical conviction carries something that no amount of argument can. Watching someone embody the text is different from hearing it argued about.

III.

The large evangelical church in the city is a different environment entirely from the CU's intimate student world. It holds multiple Sunday services; the later one draws several hundred people to a hall that has the atmosphere less of a historic church building than of a well-organised civic gathering, chairs in rows, a clear front-facing stage,

professional sound, a worship band. The notices include announcements of a monthly collection for suffering children and a forthcoming visit from an American preacher reported to have a gift for healing. The service runs for two hours.

The sermon on discipleship given by a church elder on an earlier visit makes the tradition's core demand explicit: to be a Christian is to be a disciple, and vice versa. One cannot be the one without the other. The question put to the congregation is not a gentle invitation but a direct challenge: are you a true disciple, or is your Christianity simply a family tradition, a Sunday habit, a way of managing your sins while leaving your life essentially unchanged? Jesus should be not merely saviour but Lord, over every part of life from childhood to retirement to death. The call is total. It is delivered without harshness but also without softening.

The healing service, on a later visit, presents a different face of the same tradition. A visiting preacher from the United States identifies categories of illness for which he has received what he calls anointing, specific conditions for which he believes God has authorised him to pray with particular effect. People with those conditions are invited to come forward. Some do. There are testimonies afterwards. The epistemology here is different from the careful historical argument of the Alpha course or the CU preacher: it does not invite rational

evaluation but immediate experiential confirmation. Something either happens or it does not. The congregation around the visitor receives it as entirely continuous with the sermon about King David asking God for tactical guidance before two battles. God is available, responsive, specific. This is a live hypothesis, not a historical one.

King's Church, a large evangelical congregation meeting in rented premises in central Manchester, and the church to which the Nigerian Pentecostal fellowship had kindly referred the visitor after his conversion in 2003, was visited intermittently across several years. Its 11:30 Sunday service runs two hours, with worship songs, a children's programme that leaves mid-service, and a visiting preacher whose theme on one occasion is discipleship as transformation rather than information, the distinction between following Christ and merely inheriting Christianity as a cultural habit. The question he poses is direct: are you a true disciple, or is it just a family tradition? The evangelical tradition's defining characteristic is precisely this refusal to let the question remain rhetorical. The Easter Sunday service at an evangelical church near Platt Fields, a larger, more established building with a mixed congregation of students and local families, four hundred people in the hall, has a different character again: more liturgical in structure, less charismatic in texture. The

sermon is on the Road to Emmaus. The preacher's central observation is that the two disciples who walked with the risen Jesus did not recognise him, and that many people who consider themselves Christians may be in the same position, walking alongside something they do not quite see. The observation is made without reproach. It is an invitation to honest self-examination, offered in the same argumentative spirit that characterises the tradition: here is a question. Consider it seriously. What is your honest answer?

IV.

The Alpha course, experienced across two separate runs in different settings, is worth considering carefully as a document of how the evangelical tradition understands the relationship between argument and conversion. The course is not, despite its rational framing, primarily an intellectual exercise. It is a social and experiential one. Each session combines a prepared presentation with discussion in a small group, and both the presentation and the discussion are designed to move the participant toward a decision. The discussions are not open-ended. They have a direction. The questions they raise, do you believe in the supernatural? can you accept that you have sinned? what would change if you invited Jesus into your life?,

are not invitations to extended philosophical reflection. They are steps in a sequence.

This is not a criticism of the course's intellectual honesty. The arguments it makes for the historical reliability of the gospels, for the philosophical difficulty of dismissing Jesus as merely a good teacher given the claims he made, for the psychological coherence of the concept of sin as a description of human behaviour, these are real arguments, made by real thinkers, and they deserve to be engaged with seriously. A session on evil and the devil that works through the mechanics of temptation in the Genesis narrative, how doubt is introduced, how the positive is ignored in favour of the prohibition, how blame follows transgression, is genuinely illuminating as a piece of moral psychology, regardless of whether one accepts its theological framing.

What the course cannot quite conceal, however, is the asymmetry between the openness of its questions and the fixity of its conclusions. The discussion after a session on why Jesus died ranges freely, is Christianity too focused on death rather than life? is it fair that forgiveness requires asking for it? what does free will mean if God is omniscient?, but the DVD that precedes the discussion has already given the answers. The discussion elaborates rather than investigates. The visitor who arrives with genuine uncertainty about the conclusions will find

the presentation stimulating; will not find the discussion a space for genuine agnosticism.

This is the tension at the heart of evangelical epistemology more broadly. It values reason, welcomes questions, and genuinely believes that the evidence for Christianity is sufficient to convince any honest enquirer. But it also believes the conclusion is already known, revealed, settled. The argument is real. The openness to challenge is real. The conclusion, however, is not in question. The visitor who takes the argument seriously but reaches a different conclusion has, within the tradition's framework, made an error somewhere, not exercised a legitimate intellectual freedom.

V.

Before leaving this chapter it is worth pausing on a tradition that stands adjacent to the evangelical world but belongs to a quite different lineage: the Plymouth Brethren. The gospel tent erected in a public park in summer, organised by a Brethren assembly from the suburbs, open to anyone who walks past, represents an approach to Christian proclamation that predates the Alpha course by more than a century and has none of its contemporary sophistication. There are hymns from a hymn book. There is a prayer. There is a preacher who speaks from a scripture passage and invites the unconverted to ask Jesus

into their lives. The talk is twenty minutes. The total service is forty-five. There is no food afterwards.

The Brethren, as a movement, emerged in the 1820s and 1830s partly as a reaction against the perceived formalism of established churches and partly from a deep conviction that the New Testament described a form of Christian community that had been obscured by centuries of institutional accretion. They have no ordained clergy. They have no liturgy in the formal sense. They share bread and wine in their Sunday breaking of bread meetings without a presiding minister. Their theology is conservative and their practice austere, but the austerity is principled: it reflects a genuine belief that the simplest forms of worship are the most faithful to the earliest Christian practice.

The carol services at the Brethren assembly halls, in Swinton and in Prestwich, held in November and December, have a quality that is unexpectedly affecting. The congregations are small: twenty people here, forty there. The buildings are plain. But the carols are sung with full voice and without self-consciousness, and the speakers who reflect on the birth of the child at Bethlehem do so with a simplicity that has not been processed through any contemporary communications strategy. One elder, decorating a Christmas tree as an illustration, gives each ornament a theological meaning: the

angel announces the birth, the black ball reminds us we are sinners, the dove represents the peace that only Jesus can bring. It is not sophisticated. It is entirely sincere. The tea and mince pies afterwards are generous.

What is most striking about the Brethren, seen from outside, is how little they resemble the evangelical world that shares many of their doctrinal convictions. There is no large church, no professional worship band, no Alpha course, no visiting preacher with a gift for healing. There is a room, some chairs, a hymn book, a Bible, and people who have been meeting in roughly this form for most of their lives. The rational argument for Christianity that structures evangelical outreach does not structure the Brethren service; what structures it instead is a settled practice, inherited and repeated, whose meaning does not require demonstration because it has never been seriously doubted by those performing it.

VI.

That the evangelical tradition primarily shapes conviction, the will more than the feelings, requires a final word of explanation. Conviction is not the same as certainty. Certainty is an epistemic state; you know something to be true. Conviction is something more performative: it is the state of someone who has decided to act as though something is true

and who has organised their inner life around that decision. The evangelical tradition produces conviction rather than certainty because it knows, better than any other tradition examined in this book, how thin the evidential basis for religious belief actually is, and has therefore developed, over decades of practice, an extraordinarily sophisticated set of techniques for helping people cross the gap between evidence and commitment.

The argument, the discussion, the music, the communal warmth, the sense of a decision being invited, all of these work together toward a moment at which the intellect has been sufficiently engaged that the will can act without feeling that it is simply leaping in the dark. Whether the moment of action is then, as the tradition believes, a response to the Holy Spirit's invitation, or whether it is the result of very effective social and rhetorical engineering, is a question the tradition cannot answer from inside itself. What is certain is that the techniques work: people make the commitment, hold it, and build their lives around it. The Brethren elder who has sung the same carols for fifty years and the student who prays for the first time after a CU mission week talk are both, in their different ways, living the answer to the question the tradition spends all its energy posing: will you decide? Of the communities encountered in these years, the Plymouth

Brethren were among the most evidently sincere. They were also among the most strict: no instruments in worship, no participation from the floor, a separateness from the surrounding world maintained with quiet and unyielding consistency. The sincerity and the strictness were not in tension. They were the same thing.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

The Fellowship

The Methodist Church: Withington, Chorlton, and the young adults group

> *'When light shines on a dark room, we can see the dust. Similarly we can see the decay and need of the world, not just our own needs.'*
>
> , A minister's sermon, Withington Methodist church, January 2008

I.

John Wesley, the eighteenth-century Anglican clergyman whose preaching tours of England eventually gave rise to the Methodist movement, did not set out to found a church. He set out to form people, specifically to form the poor, the labourers, the populations that the established Church of England was not, in his view, reaching adequately. His instrument was the class meeting: small groups of a dozen or so people who gathered weekly, not primarily to worship but to account to one another for how they were living. Had they resisted temptation? Been kind to their neighbours? Prayed as they had resolved to? The accountability was mutual and the group was the mechanism. You could not be Methodist alone.

This founding impulse, faith as a shared social practice, formed and maintained in the company of others, has never entirely left the tradition. It is present in the Withington Methodist church's Sunday evening service, which in January 2008 draws a congregation of perhaps twenty people to a simple room where chairs are arranged in a semicircle around a table and a large wooden cross hangs on the wall. The minister leads a service from the Methodist worship book: hymns, scripture, a short sermon, prayers of intercession for the church, the neighbourhood, the city, the world, Kofi Annan trying to resolve the Kenyan electoral crisis, people at the World Economic Forum, Christians in Iraq. Then communion: bread broken and passed around, wine shared. Tea afterwards. The two women who organise the young adults group that meets immediately after introduce themselves. The evening has the quality of a well-maintained household: functional, warm, familiar to those who live in it.

The impulse is present still more directly in the young adults group that gathers after the evening service in a side room of the same building. It is organised by two lay members, not by the minister. Its content is decided by whoever has something to offer: one Sunday a detailed presentation on numerology in the Hebrew scriptures, working through the significance of different numbers in Genesis and the New

Testament and the word values of ancient names, accompanied by three songs. The group is small, eight or ten people on a typical evening, and its informality is deliberate. It is not a Bible study in any doctrinal sense. It is a group of young people who have chosen to spend Sunday evening doing something together that involves thinking about faith. The thinking is relaxed. The something-togetherness is the point.

II.

The café church that meets on a Sunday evening in a café in Withington is a step further still from formal worship. A few people gather over food. One of the organisers distributes printed excerpts from Nietzsche's declaration of the death of God and a critical review of Richard Dawkins's attack on religion. The discussion is about what difference there is, if any, between an atheist and a believer. After the discussion, a psalm is passed around in fragments, each person receives a different verse, and the group recites it together, each person reading their verse when they feel moved to. The fragments reassemble into something whole. A hymn ends the evening.

What is notable here is what is absent. There is no liturgy. There is no ordained minister. There is no formal structure of any kind beyond the shared decision to gather and the willingness of whoever organised it to bring something

along. The Nietzsche excerpt is not there to be refuted. It is there to be thought about honestly. The psalm is not there to be expounded. It is there to be shared. The tradition being enacted is not primarily one of doctrine or sacrament or authority but of honest companionship in the presence of difficult questions. The community holds the question rather than answering it. The act of holding it together is the practice.

At Café Spirit in Chorlton, a monthly evening gathering at a church that has arranged its meeting room with activity stations rather than chairs in rows, the approach is even more experimental. Participants can colour Celtic mandala patterns with crayons while reflecting on the love of God. They can make oil-paint bookmarks using pigment floated on water, each one unique, each one taken home as a small material object carrying whatever was brought to its making. They can read from a selection of books set out on tables: the autobiography of a Trappist monk, a volume on urban graffiti art, the life of Mother Teresa, a book on Celtic spirituality, a collection of aphorisms by an Indian Jesuit writer. They can sit quietly and attempt a guided exercise in working with a remembered dream. Tea, coffee, banana cake, and chocolates are available throughout.

It would be easy to mistake this for spiritual tourism, or for a kind of Christianity so thoroughly accommodated to

the surrounding culture's preferences for non-commitment and sensory experience that it has lost any distinctively Christian content. That reading would be wrong. The Celtic patterns being coloured are patterns used for centuries in Christian devotion. The monk whose autobiography is on the table was one of the twentieth century's most serious contemplatives. The exercise of sitting with a remembered dream and imagining Jesus asking the figures in it who they are and why they are there is not a New Age technique borrowed from outside Christianity but an adaptation of the Ignatian imaginative prayer that predates it by four hundred years. What Café Spirit is doing is making available, in a format that does not require prior religious formation to enter, practices of attention and reflection that the Christian tradition has developed over centuries and that most people in the surrounding culture have no access to.

III.

The evening service at Withington in August 2008 is structured around a theme that has arrived from outside the regular liturgical calendar: the Kirchentag, the Kirchentag held that May in Bremen, a biennial gathering that brings together German Protestants across denominations, which several members of the congregation attended. The service opens with

German songs sung at the festival and Iona intercession music. Three short presentations based on Bible studies from the Kirchentag follow: the question put to Adam in Genesis, "where are you?", applied to the present; Jonah's story; and the Good Samaritan, with a discussion of whether we would stop to help the robbed man on the road today, and whether we can work toward a world where he would not be robbed in the first place. Children make paper boats.

Before the service, five people meet in the living room of one of the members to plan it. They sit around a table with notes, a song book, and maps of Bremen. They discuss how to make the service work for everyone who will attend: children need an activity; younger people need something that is not too long; traditional members of the congregation need at least one familiar hymn. They decide on the boat-making for children, the Kirchentag songs in English and German, a table of memorabilia from the trip, some photographs displayed on a board. One of them suggests the Iona response for the intercessions. It is agreed. Someone takes a note.

This planning meeting is, in its own way, as theologically interesting as the service it produces. The people around the table are lay members making collaborative decisions about how their community will worship. They are taking seriously the question of who will be in the room and

what will serve them. They are exercising a kind of pastoral imagination that is not the preserve of ordained clergy. They are being the church in the most direct sense: assembling it, shaping it, making it fit for the people who will inhabit it. The Methodist tradition has always understood that this is what the church is, not a building, not a hierarchy, not a set of doctrines, but a gathered community capable of organising its own life.

IV.

The Good Friday service in a Methodist church in Leeds, attended during a visit to the city, with twenty people present, arranges chairs in a circle around the minister, who stands in the middle. The service is meditative and slow. There is a reflection on what was done to Jesus: the ridicule, the condemnation, the execution. There are hymns. There is a reading from John's gospel covering the hours from condemnation to death. There is a quiet prayer of repentance. Then the minister says something that remains. She reminds the congregation that God did not send Jesus to condemn the world but to save it. Friday is over, she says at the end. But Sunday is coming.

The circular seating is not accidental. It expresses something about how this tradition understands the gathered community: not as an audience facing a performance but as a

circle of people facing one another, with the presiding minister at the centre rather than at the front. The format makes visible what Wesley's class meetings made visible: that the people gathered are the church, not merely its beneficiaries. The minister is there to serve the circle. The circle is not there to receive the minister.

At Heathrow Airport, in a tiny chapel in Terminal 3 on a December afternoon, a Methodist minister conducts a Christmas service for five passengers who have heard the announcement over the departure lounge tannoy and chosen to come in. The chapel is barely large enough for the chairs. Outside, boarding announcements for flights to a dozen countries compete for attention. The minister says the service will last twenty minutes and that the departure gate announcements can be heard inside if anyone needs to leave. There are two hymns from the song book. Then communion: the minister breaks bread and passes it around so that each person serves the person next to them. Wine follows. A short prayer. A handshake and a happy Christmas at the door.

It is a minor scene. What stays about it is the minister's instinct to arrange the communion so that each person serves their neighbour. The five people who have wandered in from the terminal do not know each other. They share nothing except a brief accidental proximity in an airport chapel. By the

end of the service they have fed one another. The gesture enacts, with a simplicity that requires no theological commentary, the tradition's deepest conviction about what Christian community means.

V.

Before leaving this chapter it is worth noting a tradition that sits at the edge of the Methodist world and sometimes overlaps with it: the United Reformed Church, a 1972 merger of the Congregationalist and Presbyterian traditions that has never quite found its own distinct identity in British church life. The URC congregation in Chorlton, encountered in these years, ran evening gatherings under the name Café Spirit: quiet, creative, deliberately low-pressure, drawing on Celtic spirituality and contemplative practice rather than evangelical conviction. Colouring Celtic mandala patterns, making oil-paint bookmarks, reading Thomas Merton with tea and banana cake. It was Christianity as a kind of gentle workshop, without claims and without pressure. The people who came were clearly searching for something and were being given space rather than answers. Whether that is enough is a question the tradition itself seems to hold open.

There is a moment in a Withington evening service that stays: the minister moving through the small room after the service,

stopping at each person, unhurried, asking and waiting for the actual answer. Not pastoral performance. Just attention. That the Methodist tradition primarily shapes community, specifically the quality of attention people pay to one another, requires a little unpacking. Community is an easy word to use and a hard thing to mean precisely. Every tradition described in this book has some form of community. The UPC community is intense, total, and clearly bounded. The LDS community is warm, organised, and oriented around family. The Anglican chaplaincy community is diverse, informal, and intellectually rich. What is specific about the Methodist community, at least as encountered in these years, is that it seems to understand the community itself as the primary spiritual practice, not just the container in which other spiritual practices occur.

This is a subtle but important distinction. In the evangelical tradition, the community exists to support and sustain the individual's relationship with God. In the Catholic tradition, the community is the body of Christ gathered around the sacraments. In the UPC, the community is the company of those who are pursuing the same demanding holiness. In each case the community serves something that transcends it. In the Methodist world encountered here, in the café discussions, the young adults group, the Kirchentag planning meeting, the

circle of chairs in Leeds, the five strangers feeding each other in an airport, the community does not seem to be in service of something else. It seems to be the thing itself.

This does not mean that God is absent. The Withington minister's sermon about light and darkness, about the choice to live in the strength of light and to notice the decay of the world rather than turning the light off, is genuinely theological and genuinely serious. The Café Spirit exercises in Celtic colouring and dream reflection are oriented toward something beyond the room. The psalm recited in fragments in the Withington café is addressed to God. But in all of these the movement is outward and horizontal, toward the world, toward the neighbour, toward the person sitting next to you who is also holding a fragment of the psalm, as much as it is vertical and devotional. Wesley's question to his class meetings was not primarily "How is your relationship with God?" but "How are you living?" The answer was expected to involve other people.

VI.

There is a melancholy that attaches to the Methodist tradition in England that is absent from its history in other parts of the world, where it is still growing rapidly. In England it is an old presence, declining in numbers, occupying buildings that were

once filled to their galleries on Sunday mornings and now hold handfuls of people in semicircles. The theological question this raises is one the tradition has not fully answered: if community is the primary spiritual practice, what does it mean when the community is contracting? Wesley's original insight was that the gospel had to go to the people, not wait for them to come to the church. The contemporary Methodist church in England has, to a significant degree, reversed this: it waits. The warmth of the community it offers is real. But warmth requires a body to hold it, and the body is ageing. The Withington evening service draws perhaps twenty people to a room that could hold ten times that. The café church draws a few. Café Spirit draws a few more. The young adults group after the Sunday service draws eight or ten. These are not failing communities. But they are small ones, and they know it.

What they have preserved, in their smallness, is something that perhaps only smallness can preserve: the sense that everyone in the room matters specifically, not generically. At a large evangelical church of four hundred people the individual worshipper is present in a crowd. At the Withington evening service the minister knows that one of the regular members is dealing with a difficult situation at work and has included a prayer for people in that position without naming it. This is pastoral attention of a kind that requires knowing

people rather than serving a demographic. It is one of the things Wesley's class meetings were designed to produce, and it has survived.

The evening ends, as the Withington evening service always ends, with tea. The minister moves through the small room and speaks to people. The women who organise the young adults group consult briefly about next Sunday. Someone asks after someone else's family member. Someone else makes a note in a diary. The wooden cross remains on the wall. The chairs remain in their semicircle. Outside, Withington goes about its Sunday evening. Inside, something that is neither quite a service nor quite a social gathering and is entirely both comes quietly to its end.

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CHAPTER NINE

The Sabbath Keepers

The Seventh Day Adventist Church, Manchester

> *'These are the end days. The prophecies of Daniel are applicable even in modern times.'*
>
> , A student bible study, Friday evening, November 2007

I.

Every religious tradition organises time in some way. Christianity marks the liturgical year, Advent, Christmas, Lent, Easter, Pentecost, and the weekly rhythm of Sunday worship. Islam structures the day around five prayer times and the week around Friday's congregational prayer. Judaism shapes the week around the Sabbath, from sunset on Friday to nightfall on Saturday, within which no ordinary work is permitted. What is distinctive about the Seventh Day Adventist tradition is that it has placed this specifically Jewish marking of time, the seventh-day sabbath rather than the Christian first-day Sunday, at the absolute centre of its theology and practice. The sabbath is not a preference or a custom. It is a commandment, one of the original ten, and the Adventist reading of both scripture and history makes observing it correctly the mark of the

faithful remnant in what the tradition understands to be the last days before Christ's return.

The Seventh Day Adventist church emerged in the United States in the 1840s, in the aftermath of the Great Disappointment: the failed prediction by the Baptist preacher William Miller that Christ would return in 1844. From the groups that gathered to make sense of this failure came a new movement, shaped by several distinctive convictions, the seventh-day sabbath, the sleep of the dead until resurrection, the importance of health as a spiritual discipline, the imminence of the Second Coming, that set it apart from the evangelical Protestantism in which it was rooted. Ellen White, one of its founding figures, was a prolific writer whose visions and writings became foundational texts for the tradition. By the twenty-first century the church had become one of the fastest-growing Protestant denominations in the world, with particular strength in Africa, South America, and parts of Asia. Its presence in Manchester, with a central congregation and a student society, reflects this global reach: on any given Friday evening the people who gather belong to a community that spans more than two hundred countries.

The student bible study meets on Friday evenings, the beginning of the sabbath, in a house not far from the university. There are five or six people on a typical week:

students from different countries, health-conscious in their eating habits, carrying their hymn books. The meeting begins with a prayer, sometimes more than one. Then hymns. Then the study itself, with a specific passage assigned and discussed. Then more prayer, more hymns, a closing prayer. Then vegetarian snacks and conversation. The format is simple. What gives it weight is the day on which it occurs: these people have made a specific, costly choice to be here on a Friday evening rather than anywhere else, and that choice is the first act of the sabbath.

II.

The sabbath Saturday service at the central church runs from ten in the morning until one in the afternoon. Bible study precedes the main service, with a topic assigned from the church's quarterly lesson guide, on one occasion the fall of Adam and what "death" means in the Genesis account, whether mental, spiritual, or physical. The main service follows: hymns, prayers, a children's segment, a sermon. On this particular occasion the sermon is about trusting in Jesus even when people treat you badly. The congregation is diverse in age and nationality. The singing is strong.

The central text of the student Friday sessions, encountered repeatedly across these months, is the book of

Daniel. Daniel is the young Jewish nobleman taken into Babylonian captivity who refuses the king's food, meat and wine that would have made him ritually impure, and is rewarded with health and wisdom exceeding his peers. His companions Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refuse to worship the golden idol the king has constructed, even when threatened with the furnace. Later Daniel himself is thrown into the lions' den for continuing to pray despite a royal prohibition. Throughout, those who maintain their faithfulness under pressure are vindicated; those who compromise are destroyed or humbled.

The book's prophetic sections, Nebuchadnezzar's dream of a statue made of different metals, Daniel's own visions of beasts and kingdoms, are read by the Adventist tradition as a detailed map of world history from Babylon to the present and beyond, with the final kingdom of God still to come. The discussion at the student bible study does not treat this as ancient allegory. It treats it as applicable now. The egoistic pride that brought Nebuchadnezzar low, the declaration that Babylon is mine, that I am its king, that I have made it, is recognisable in the present. The persecution of those who will not compromise their faith is ongoing. These are the end days. Daniel knew it. We are living in the final chapters of the prophecy he received.

The youth day at the central church structures itself as a journey, a flight, specifically, with Jesus as the pilot and a pastor as co-pilot, flying over the land of persecution, with diversions representing temptations and opposition, heading for the Holy Land of Jerusalem. The organisational metaphor is elaborate, drawn from the text reference that frames the event. But the substance beneath the metaphor is serious. The pastor speaks directly to a problem the congregation knows well: young people are leaving. They feel the generation gap between elders who criticise without encouraging and youth who feel unseen and judged. Friends tempt them to break their commitments and then mock them when they give way. He invites the young people to come forward and recommit. Their parents are asked to pray for them. Then everyone holds hands and prays together. The vegetarian meal that follows is not incidental. It is part of the same practice.

III.

The Christmas carol concert at the central church runs from four to seven in the afternoon and is one of the more musically distinguished evenings in these years of churchgoing. A flute plays a meditative version of a familiar carol. There is a performance of a Bach piece. An original poem written by a student member reflects on the circumstances of the Nativity

with quiet seriousness. A song describes what the Incarnation cost Jesus in terms of his divine attributes: he gave up omnipresence, the ability to be everywhere at once; he gave up the eternal perspective, and could no longer see beyond death. But still he had faith. The framing is unusual and affecting. Most Christmas worship focuses on what humanity gained. This meditation focuses on what God gave up.

The second half of the concert is given to a presentation by a young woman who has spent six years teaching at a church-run school in a remote area of equatorial South America. The facilities are primitive in ways that are difficult to convey to a Manchester audience: no proper mattresses, no qualified teachers, fourteen hours from the nearest hospital, a river for bathing that is infested with piranhas, cooking for sixty children over a single open fire. Three major building projects are needed before the rains come: a permanent kitchen, a concrete road, a better dormitory. Some money has come from a donor. The rest needs to be raised tonight.

The pastor explains that the evening is dedicated to fundraising for this school. He observes that at Christmas it is tempting to spend on giving to those who already have enough. These children, in the forest, do not have Christmas gifts at all. The collection that follows is generous. What is notable is the

directness of the connection: a congregation in Manchester, gathered to sing carols, being asked to think concretely about children in South America who need a kitchen built before January. The tradition's strong missionary orientation, its global reach, its sense of itself as a worldwide community with specific practical obligations to its most vulnerable members, is present in this moment without sentimentality.

IV.

The international students day, held annually at the central church and attended by people from New York, from different parts of the United Kingdom, and from many other countries, is the most vivid expression of the tradition's global character. The morning session includes talks, hymns, and an international prayer: students from different countries each read a section of the prayer in their own language. English gives way to French, then to a language the visitor cannot identify, then to another, then back to English. The congregation prays in chorus across linguistic boundaries, each voice carrying the same intention in its own words.

The afternoon concert has singing that is, without exaggeration, the most beautiful choral singing encountered in these years of attendance at Christian services across many traditions. The Adventist tradition has a strong musical culture

rooted partly in its own hymnal and partly in the gospel music traditions of its African and African-American membership. The singers are not professional. They are members of the congregation who have rehearsed. But the quality of the sound they produce, the blend, the precision, the emotional seriousness with which they treat the material, is of a different order from what is encountered in most Sunday services. Music here is not background or atmosphere. It is an act of worship given the same preparation and intentionality as the sermon.

In a home on a weekday evening, a small group of six gathers for a sabbath bible study that has been rescheduled from the usual Friday. They chat first, waiting for latecomers who arrive almost an hour after the planned start time. When the meeting finally begins, no one is impatient. The prayers are unhurried. The hymns, sung without accompaniment, from memory, fill the small room. The bible study, from the Psalms, focuses on the wonders of nature: God making ice and then melting it, the ordinary processes of weather that the psalm frames as continuous divine action. After the closing prayer, vegetarian burgers are shared and the conversation continues until late. The sabbath, which began the previous Friday at sunset, has infused the week with a different quality of time.

V.

That the Adventist tradition primarily shapes time, the experience of the week, requires some unpacking. What is distinctive about the Adventist approach is the sharpness of the boundary it draws and the doctrinal weight it assigns to that boundary. The sabbath is not merely a day of rest or a cultural preference. It is the sign of the covenant between God and the faithful remnant in the last days. To observe it correctly is to align oneself with the history of salvation. To neglect it is not a minor failure of practice but a theologically significant defection.

This makes the sabbath something qualitatively different from, say, the Anglican Sunday service, which one may attend or miss without any strong doctrinal consequence. The Adventist Friday evening meeting is the beginning of a twenty-four-hour period during which ordinary time is suspended. The student who chooses to be at the bible study rather than anywhere else on a Friday evening is not merely making a scheduling decision. They are making a statement about what kind of person they are and what kind of world they believe they inhabit. They are one of the people who keep the seventh day. That is an identity, not merely a habit.

The consequence of this is a particular texture to Adventist social life. Because the sabbath is communal, kept

together, not alone, it creates a strong gravitational pull toward the congregation. The people you spend Friday evening and Saturday with, week after week, become the people you know most intimately. The shared commitment to health, the vegetarian diet, the abstinence from alcohol and tobacco, the concern for the body as a temple, further distinguishes the community from its surroundings and reinforces the sense of a people set apart. Not aggressively set apart: the international students day is explicitly welcoming, the carol concert is open to all, the home bible study receives visitors warmly. But set apart nonetheless. Daniel and his companions did not eat the king's meat. The tradition has not forgotten why.

VI.

There is a moment in the youth day address that stays. The pastor is speaking about the difficulty of maintaining one's commitments when friends mock those who refuse to compromise. He tells a story: a group of friends keeps placing pork in someone's food without their knowledge. When the person eventually gives way and eats it, the friends do not respect them for it. They mock them instead. The specific food, pork, which the Adventist tradition regards as unclean on the basis of Old Testament dietary law, is not incidental. It is the sign of a commitment being tested, and the moral of the

story is not that the commitment was unreasonable but that yielding to pressure brings neither acceptance nor peace.

The story is told to young people who are visibly struggling with the question of how to maintain a distinctively Adventist identity in a culture that neither understands nor respects it. The answer the pastor offers is not to become more aggressive in its defence or more confident in its proclamation. It is to recommit, quietly, in the company of the community. Come forward. Hold hands. Pray together. Then eat together, the meal that the tradition has prepared: vegetarian, shared, nourishing. The sabbath will come again on Friday.

A visitor who has spent a Friday evening in a small house with six people praying over psalms and sharing veggie burgers, and a Saturday in a large church hall where students from twenty countries have prayed in their own languages and sung together with a beauty that could not have been anticipated, leaves with a specific kind of residue. It is not the residue of argument, as with the evangelicals, or of interior experience, as with the Jesuits, or of embodied surrender, as with the UPC. It is something closer to the residue of a rhythm, a sense that a week has a shape, that some time is different from other time, that the choice of how to spend Friday evening is a more significant choice than it appears. The

sabbath, for those who keep it, is not a restriction on ordinary life. It is the frame within which ordinary life becomes legible.

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CHAPTER TEN

The Church Ahead of the Church

The Student Christian Movement

> *'SCM has always been more radical, fighting for social justice and more inclusive towards all people irrespective of race, sexuality and other boundaries. We need to be the church ahead of the church.'*
>
> , An archdeacon speaking at the SCM 120th anniversary service, Manchester Cathedral, March 2009

I.

In 1889, a small group of Christian students in Britain formed a movement whose explicit aim was to bring the universities into active relationship with the Christian faith. The Student Christian Movement grew quickly, spreading across British, Scottish, and eventually international campuses, and for several decades it was the dominant form of organised Christian student life in Britain. Then, in 1930, it divided. The more evangelical wing separated to form what became the Christian Union network, focused on personal conversion and gospel proclamation. The SCM continued, but in a different direction: toward social justice, toward ecumenism, toward a Christianity that understood the gospel as having something to say not just

about individual souls but about poverty, war, race, gender, and power.

By the time the movement reaches its 120th anniversary service at Manchester Cathedral in March 2009, it is smaller than it was at its height, but it is recognisably the same organisation: radical, inclusive, ecumenical, and consciously positioned at the edge of what mainstream Christianity is willing to say. More than fifty people attend the service, some having driven from Bristol, some who joined in the 1950s sitting alongside current students. The gathering song moves between English and Shona. The address given by a senior Anglican clergyman frames the SCM's identity in the phrase it has used of itself: the church ahead of the church. The vision, he says, is to claim God's love as having no boundaries, and to actually live that claim, not just assert it.

The SCM meets fortnightly at the university chaplaincy, usually with fifteen to twenty people, always with food. Its meetings cover a range of topics determined by whoever has something to bring: Hindu and Christian approaches to transcendence, led by a theology PhD student; a talk on the Spanish liberation theologian Jon Sobrino, given by a university lecturer; discussions of the Old Testament's violent passages and what to do with them. The tone is consistently that of people who take their faith seriously

enough to argue with it, who would rather confront a difficult text honestly than explain it away, and who assume that what Christianity says about God has implications for what it should say about everything else.

II.

Liberation theology is the tradition that most clearly defines the SCM's theological character, though it is not the only one it draws on. The lecture on Jon Sobrino opens with a geography lesson: El Salvador, small and beautiful, ravaged by floods and volcanoes, marked by one of the sharpest gaps between rich and poor in the Western hemisphere. From this geography the theology emerges. Sobrino, a Spanish Jesuit working at the Central American university in San Salvador, is part of a tradition that began in the 1960s when Latin American Catholic theologians started asking what the gospel looks like from the perspective of the poor rather than from the perspective of the institution.

The tradition's central argument is simple: that Jesus was poor, lived among the poor, was killed by the powerful, and rose again. If that is true, then a theology that prioritises the spiritual over the material, or the institutional over the marginal, has misread its own texts. The God of the Gospels is recognisably present in the village whose men were

massacred and whose women and children were exhumed from a mass grave. The church that blessed the military regime that carried out that massacre has a problem that no amount of theological sophistication can paper over.

The Vatican has not found this comfortable. A notification issued against Sobrino in 2007, described in the meeting by the lecturer who presents it, charges him with basing his theology on the poor rather than on the faith of the church, with insufficiently asserting the divinity of Christ, and with misrepresenting the salvific value of his death. He has been banned from teaching theology. The Vatican's objections are precisely those that the SCM meeting finds most telling as evidence for Sobrino's importance: a theology that troubles the institution is probably touching something the institution would rather leave alone.

The meeting ends with a dedication to a boy who shared his bread generously but died of cancer because his family could not afford treatment. Two minutes of silence for the people of El Salvador. Then the Lord's Prayer. The combination, academic lecture, political analysis, moment of silence, prayer, is characteristic of the SCM's method: it does not separate the intellectual from the devotional, or the political from the spiritual. They are aspects of the same thing.

III.

The SCM annual conference brings together student members from across Britain for a residential weekend. The programme is dense: morning worship in multiple languages, workshops on theology and social justice, evening sessions on gender and sexuality and violence. What is notable is not any individual session but the cumulative effect of the whole, the assumption that runs through everything that Christian faith is not a private spiritual condition but a public intellectual and ethical commitment, and that the work of thinking about it carefully is never finished.

A session on faith, gender, and sexuality given by a theologian moves through three biblical passages, each of which has been used to justify the subordination of women or the condemnation of homosexuality, and examines what each passage actually says in its historical and linguistic context. The Hebrew word used in Genesis 2 when God creates woman from the rib of man is not the word for 'woman' as subordinate, she argues; it is a word used elsewhere for both male and female. The passage in 1 Timothy that has been used to silence women in church was written in a specific context of a specific problem in a specific community. The verse in Leviticus that prohibits a man lying with a man as with a woman may refer to a specific ritual practice in a specific cultic

context, not to all same-sex relations for all time. These are not new arguments in academic theology. They are new in many church contexts. The SCM treats them as basic literacy.

A session on a transgendered priest, given by the priest herself, moves between the scientific and the theological with a sureness that comes from having had to think about both in order to understand her own existence. She explains biological sex and gender as distinct categories, cites statistics on intersex conditions, quotes a Spanish priest who told her that what you are is God's gift to you, and what you become is your gift to God. She describes the difficulty her parents had in accepting her transition. She discusses the Genesis passage in which God creates humanity in the divine image: does this mean God endorses a two-gendered world? Or does it mean something harder and stranger than that, something about the image of God being more capacious than any human category?

A session on masculinity and violence, led by a speaker from a peace organisation, shows clips from an American documentary about how boys from poorer backgrounds are forced by peer culture into performing a violent and emotionally closed version of manhood. The speaker's point is not primarily about gender but about violence: the crisis of masculinity is the crisis of a culture that treats violence as redemptive, and Christianity has something specific to say

about that because its central symbol is a man who was tortured to death and refused to respond in kind. The question the speaker asks the room is: where is the old wise man, the Gandalf figure, gone? What happened to models of masculinity that were not about domination?

IV.

The 120th anniversary service at Manchester Cathedral gathers the SCM's history into a single afternoon. A woman who joined in the 1950s shares her memory with a current student: it was very radical then, she says, and it still is. The gathering song, Uyai Mose, sung in Shona, moves between languages in a building that has stood at the centre of English religious life for centuries. The red cards distributed with the service sheet ask each person to write a prayer, which is collected along with the offering. The song sung as the offertory has a line that functions almost as a manifesto: heaven shall not wait for the rich to share their fortunes, or for thoughts of compassion divorced from cries of pain.

The movement's history is one of repeated difficulty with the institutions it critiques. It broke from the CU in 1930 because it was too inclusive. It broke more sharply from mainstream church life in the 1950s and 1960s because it was too activist. It has been accused at various points of being

insufficiently evangelical, insufficiently orthodox, insufficiently focused on personal conversion. Its response to each accusation has been the same: to point to the Gospels, where Jesus spent most of his time with people the institution had excluded, and to ask what it means to follow him.

The archdeacon's address at the 120th anniversary makes the claim precisely. Jesus's coming, he says, was infinity entering finite time to lead people to infinite life. The life Jesus led was one of relentless inclusion: the poor, the tax collector, the Samaritan, the woman at the well, the leper. God's love has no boundaries. To claim to be the church ahead of the church is to take that claim seriously enough to let it challenge every boundary the church has drawn around itself.

V.

There is a particular SCM meeting that stays. A session on liberation theology is followed by a long silence. Someone eventually says: but what does this require of me, here, this week? The question is not rhetorical. Nobody rushes to answer it. If the Anglican chaplaincy cultivates awareness, and the Pentecostal community works on the body, the SCM cultivates conscience: the capacity for moral discomfort in the presence of injustice, and the refusal to dissolve it into the merely spiritual. This is not the same as political activism, though it

often produces it. It is something more specifically theological: the conviction that what one believes about God has implications for how one is obliged to live, and that those implications extend well beyond personal virtue into the structures of society.

The SCM differs from the evangelical tradition in a specific way worth noting. Both take Christianity seriously as an intellectual and ethical commitment. Both believe the faith has something to say about how the world should be organised. But where the evangelical tradition tends to read the gospel as addressing the individual first, personal sin, personal conversion, personal relationship with God, the SCM reads it as addressing the collective first. The question it brings to the text is not primarily "what must I do to be saved?" but "what does this mean for how we treat one another?". The difference is not absolute, both ask both questions, but the order of priority produces very different theologies and very different communities.

A visitor who spends time with the SCM leaves with a specific residue: the sense that Christian faith, taken seriously, is more politically uncomfortable than any of its institutional expressions usually acknowledge. The Vatican is uncomfortable with Sobrino. Many churches are uncomfortable with queer theology. Many Christians are

uncomfortable with a reading of the gospels that makes the treatment of the poor the primary criterion of faithfulness. The SCM makes you sit with that discomfort rather than resolving it. Its meetings end with the Lord's Prayer, which is to say they end with a very old text that asks for God's kingdom to come on earth as it is in heaven, and takes seriously the question of what that would actually require.

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Portable Gospel

The Alpha Course: a curriculum without a church

> *'Is belief in Christ simply an intellectual argument? Or is it more emotional, at the level of relationship? Or perhaps parts of both?'*
>
> , Discussion after an Alpha session, Manchester, 2010

I.

Every chapter in this book describes a community: a people who gather regularly, who know each other's names, who share a practice and a theology and a particular way of being together in the world. The Alpha course is different. It is not a community. It is a curriculum, a packaged, reproducible, exportable programme that can be inserted into any Christian community, or into none. It began at a wealthy Anglican church in west London in 1977, was taken over and radically revised in 1990, and has since run in 140 countries and 170 languages, reaching, by its own count, more than thirty million people. It has been used in Catholic parishes, Methodist halls, prison cells, office buildings, and university chaplaincies. The building that houses it is irrelevant. The denomination that endorses it is incidental. The curriculum is the constant.

This is the feature of the Alpha course that makes it worth a chapter of its own. All the other communities in this book have specific, local, historically rooted identities that shape what happens inside them. The Alpha course has deliberately shed those identities. Its designers made a conscious decision to avoid any teaching that is specific to one denomination, nothing on Catholic sacramental theology, nothing on baptismal disputes between Baptists and Anglicans, nothing on Marian devotion, nothing that would make the course unusable by any church willing to host it. The result is a Christianity that has been distilled to what its creators believe is its transferable essence: who Jesus is, why he died, how to live the Christian life. Everything else is secondary. Everything else can wait until after the course, when the participant joins a specific church and encounters its specific traditions.

One scholar described Alpha as a paradoxical hybrid of rationalistic conservatism and charismatic expressivism: intellectually, it argues the case for Christianity with the tools of evidence and historical reasoning; experientially, it builds toward a weekend away in which participants are invited to receive the Holy Spirit. The two halves seem to belong to different traditions, and they do, the former to the public-school evangelical camps that shaped the course's author in the 1970s, the latter to the charismatic renewal movement that

transformed his home church in the 1980s. The hybrid is not an accident. It is the product of a specific institutional history, and it produces a specific kind of encounter with Christianity: one that tries to satisfy both the sceptical intellect and the hungering spirit simultaneously.

II.

The course is encountered twice during the years covered by this book: first at a Methodist church in 2008, in a small group of eight people watching a downloaded lecture on a laptop; then at a university chaplaincy in 2010, in a Bible study group of Taiwanese students. The two settings could hardly be more different. The first is intimate, slightly makeshift, with snacks and chocolates and juice, and a discussion that ranges freely once the video ends. The second is a more structured setting, embedded in an existing community, with the course serving as a framework for a group that already knows each other. In both cases the course itself is identical: the same talks, the same questions, the same sequence of topics. The container changes. The content does not.

The first session is titled, with characteristic directness: is Christianity boring, untrue, or irrelevant? The course author, a former barrister who retrained as an Anglican priest, dispatches each objection in turn. On boredom: the question

is whether Jesus was who he claimed to be, and if he was, boredom is not a category that applies. On untruth: the historical evidence for Jesus' existence and crucifixion is solid by ancient standards, drawn from non-Christian as well as Christian sources. On irrelevance: only if the question of what happens when you die is irrelevant. The rhetorical strategy is consistent throughout the course: take the objection seriously, state it fairly, then argue against it with historical examples, philosophical reasoning, and occasional humour. The author's legal training is visible in every session. He builds a case.

The session on why Jesus died works through four images from the New Testament for what the atonement means: a transaction in a marketplace, a verdict in a law court, a restoration of a broken relationship, a battle won against an enemy. The course does not ask the participant to choose between these images. It presents them as complementary perspectives on an event that exceeds any single framework. The session ends with an invitation: a quiet prayer, said by anyone who wishes, asking forgiveness for past sins and inviting Jesus into their life. The invitation is gentle. It is also specific. Something is being asked.

A session on sin examines evil through the Genesis account of the serpent's temptation: the doubt introduced into Eve's mind, the prohibition isolated from all the permissions

surrounding it, the consequences denied. The analysis is psychologically sharp. It maps accurately onto how temptation works, the narrowing of attention onto what is forbidden, the dismissal of what is permitted, the rationalisation of consequences. Whether or not one accepts the theological framework, the moral psychology is recognisable. A session on prayer explores what prayer is, how to do it, whether it works, and what it means to say that an omniscient God responds to specific requests. The discussion that follows is one of the most genuinely open conversations in these years of churchgoing: people share when they have prayed and whether they felt anything happened, what the relationship between prayer and coincidence might be, whether God's omniscience makes prayer redundant or necessary.

III.

The course's cross-denominational reach is not accidental. It is the result of a deliberate design choice to strip out everything that divides Christians and retain only what unites them. The author has said explicitly that what unites Christians is infinitely greater than what divides them. The course embodies this conviction structurally: Catholic, Baptist, Methodist, and Pentecostal churches can all run it without encountering anything that contradicts their specific traditions, because

anything that might do so has been removed. The course is not ecumenical in the sense of engaging seriously with the differences between traditions and finding common ground through dialogue. It is ecumenical in a more radical sense: it has decided that the differences do not matter for this purpose, and proceeded accordingly.

This produces a Christianity that is genuinely unusual: sincere, warm, intellectually serious, emotionally engaging, and deliberately unlocated. The participant who completes the course has been introduced to a version of Christian faith that is not specifically Anglican, or Catholic, or Pentecostal, or Baptist. They have met Jesus, in the course's framing, before they have met any particular church's Jesus. The assumption is that the particular will follow the universal: once someone is convinced of the core, they can find a community that will give it specific shape. In practice this means the course functions as a kind of funnel, gathering people from the surrounding secular world and directing them toward whichever church hosted it.

The eight people sitting in a Methodist church watching a downloaded video on a laptop are not being inducted into Methodism. They are being offered Christianity-in-general, in a Methodist building, by Methodist hospitality. Whether any of them will stay in that building after the course

ends, or go elsewhere, or go nowhere, is not the course's concern. Its task is to present the case. What happens next is between the participant and God, and, the course hopes, between the participant and some specific local church.

IV.

The discussion after the session on sin is the most illuminating moment in these two runs of the course. The group has watched the video, which is confident and theologically clear. The discussion that follows is not. People push back on the death-centredness of Christian theology: is it not strange, one person says, to focus so heavily on the death of Jesus rather than his life and teaching? Another responds that the death is precisely what distinguishes Christianity from other systems of moral wisdom: it makes a specific claim about what happened and what it means, not just a set of recommendations for living well. The group discusses free will in the presence of an omniscient God. It discusses whether sin is a useful category or a harmful one. It discusses the image of scales with sin on one side and grace on the other.

None of these discussions reach a conclusion. The course does not ask them to. The discussion is time-limited, and the next session is already scheduled. But something in the quality of the discussion reveals a tension at the heart of the

course's design. The talks are structured to build toward a conclusion: Christianity is true, Jesus died for your sins, you should accept this. The discussions are structured to feel open: all questions are welcome, no one is pressured. The tension between these two dynamics is present in every session. The talks point in one direction. The discussions create the impression of having pointed nowhere in particular. The question of what kind of intellectual honesty this combination represents is one the course cannot answer about itself.

A visitor who attends both runs of the course, in two different settings, leaves with a clear sense of what the Alpha course is very good at: it takes the central claims of Christianity seriously as claims, states them clearly, argues for them intelligently, and creates a social environment in which people who would not normally discuss religion find themselves doing so with some depth. These are genuine achievements. What it is less good at is allowing those claims to be genuinely contested. The discussion after the talk on whether God exists is not a genuine debate. The conclusion is already present in the room before the discussion begins, in the person who organised the course, in the shape of the sessions that have preceded this one and the sessions that will follow it. The openness is real but bounded. The boundary is just not announced.

V.

The Alpha course is harder to characterise than the community chapters, precisely because it is not a community. It does not primarily shape a lasting human capacity the way a church does. What it shapes is a moment: the threshold experience of being invited to commit, carefully engineered and warmly delivered. Every session moves toward that invitation. The Holy Spirit weekend, attended on one of the two occasions the course is encountered, represents the experiential dimension of what the intellectual sessions have been building toward: not just a case to be accepted but an encounter to be had. The weekend is held away from the city, with the group of course participants gathered together overnight. The atmosphere is unlike anything in the weekly sessions: warmer, more informal, deliberately stripped of the lecture format. There is worship. There is prayer. There is the specific invitation of the charismatic tradition: to open oneself to the Spirit, to receive rather than argue. What happens in that room is genuinely difficult to describe without either overclaiming or dismissing it. The visitor is aware of resistance, something in the self that holds back, that watches from a slight distance even as the room fills with a warmth that is palpably shared. And then, at some point, something gives. Not dramatically. Not with tongues or falling. But a sense of being loved, specifically and without condition, that does not feel manufactured by the

group or the atmosphere, though both are present. The ego, as the visitor thinks of it afterwards, resists, and love wins. The fellowship of the other participants, many of them students encountering Christianity for the first time, carries its own weight: eight or ten people in a room, finding that they are being offered something they did not know they were looking for. Whether the encounter is with God or with the best version of a community's collective attention is a question the course is not interested in posing. The Alpha approach trusts that the experience will answer it.

The course's portability is both its greatest strength and its most interesting limitation. By being usable everywhere, it belongs nowhere. By stripping out the particular, it offers the universal, but the universal, encountered in abstraction, may be harder to hold onto than the particular. The eight people in the Methodist church, sitting with their chocolates and their juice and their genuine questions, are being offered Christianity's essence. What they are not being offered, at least not by the course itself, is Christianity's texture: the specific hymns that have been sung in a specific building for a hundred years, the specific community that has formed around a specific practice, the specific arguments that a specific tradition has had with itself over centuries. Those things are what the rest of this book is about. The Alpha course is what happens when someone

decides they can be separated from their container and offered on their own.

Whether that is true, whether Christianity can be effectively transmitted as a portable curriculum rather than as a living tradition, is a question thirty million participants are answering, in their own ways, in 140 countries. The two small groups encountered in Manchester do not resolve it. They illustrate it. Sitting in a Methodist hall with a laptop and some snacks, watching a barrister-turned-priest make the case for the resurrection, is an experience unlike any other in these years of churchgoing. It is simultaneously ordinary and strange: ordinary because the questions being discussed are the ordinary questions of a human life, strange because the setting has been so carefully arranged to feel like no setting in particular.

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CHAPTER TWELVE

Christianity at Scale

The Bremen Kirchentag, May 2009

> *'The world is here. Africa, India, Europe, America. Singing the same song.'*
>
> , Personal notes, closing service, Bremen Kirchentag, May 2009

I.

Every community described in this book is small. The university chaplaincy draws twenty people on a Sunday evening. The Adventist student bible study meets in someone's living room with six chairs. The Plymouth Brethren carol service in Prestwich fits forty people in a gospel hall. The Quaker meeting for worship on Mount Street seats perhaps thirty. Even the largest evangelical churches encountered in these years, four hundred people in a Manchester church hall on Easter Sunday, are intimate by the standards of what Christianity has been capable of at scale. The Kirchentag is different in kind, not just in degree. It is Christianity gathered in its hundreds of thousands: a five-day biennial festival held across German cities, and in May 2009 in Bremen, that draws more than a hundred thousand participants to lectures, Bible

studies, concerts, debates, exhibitions, and an open-air closing service attended by sixty thousand people on a meadow by the river Weser. The Kirchentag is not the festival of any single German Protestant denomination. It is a gathering that represents the breadth of German Protestantism: Lutheran, Reformed, United, and every shade between, together with ecumenical guests from Catholic and international traditions. Its closest English equivalent in spirit, though not in scale, is Greenbelt, the annual liberal Anglican arts and faith festival described in the chapter on the Church of England.

The Kirchentag, the word means simply "church day," though the event occupies a full week, is a German Protestant lay movement whose history is inseparable from the history of Germany itself. It was founded in 1949, four years after the end of the Second World War, by a Lutheran layman who believed that German Christians needed a space to gather that was not controlled by the institutional church, where they could wrestle publicly with the great questions facing their society and their faith. From the beginning it was a lay movement: no clergy in charge, no denominational line to hold, no theological consensus required for participation. It grew through the 1950s and became one of the largest recurring gatherings in Europe. Then, in 1961, the Berlin Wall divided it. East and West held separate Kirchentags for twenty-

eight years. When the Wall fell in 1989 and the two reunited, the reunion was described by those present as one of the most emotionally overwhelming moments in the movement's history.

A commemorative evening on the first night of the 2009 event screens footage from every decade: the 1950s gatherings in the rubble of a country rebuilding itself, the 1961 event that was the last held in common before the Wall went up, the long years of separation, the reunion. A son of the movement's founder speaks about his father's vision. A former organiser of the West German Kirchentag describes being allowed, once, to visit the East, only after an interview with the Politburo, only on condition of ideological neutrality. He spoke, in his talk across the Wall, of how under the eyes of God all people are one regardless of political outlook. The audience, unsure whether they were permitted to applaud, hesitated and then clapped. The memory of that moment, retold in Bremen forty years later, makes the room go very quiet.

II.

The festival's programme is built around the biblical question put to Adam after the fall: "Mortal, where are you?" It is a question about accountability, about the refusal to hide, about

the obligation to answer honestly for where one stands and what one is doing there. The question runs through every day of the event as a thread connecting discussions that seem otherwise to have little in common: a theologians' debate about ecology and stem cell research and Luther's model of individual biblical interpretation; a session on globalisation and migration; a panel on global financial responsibility with the president of the World Bank; a forum on India's caste system and the experience of Dalits; an Africa dialogue on the charismatic church, Apartheid, and the relationship between religion and power. The sessions do not resolve any of these questions. They are not designed to. They are designed to hold them publicly, in the presence of people who take seriously their obligation to have an answer.

The migration session on the first day is the most dramatically structured. Three people give testimony about what migration has meant in their own lives. An Indonesian woman describes her years studying medicine in Munich during the Asian financial crisis: the bureaucratic trap of needing three permits each of which required the other two, the kindness of strangers at each stage, the eventual qualification that allowed her to become a doctor. A Tamil woman from Sri Lanka describes her family's harassment by both sides of a civil war, the violence she experienced, the fake

passport, the long journey to safety. An East German Lutheran pastor describes his decision to serve in Norway, the surprise of being genuinely welcomed, the contrast between the competitive culture he had left and the one he found. Three lives, three continents of experience, one question: what does it mean to be a stranger, and what does it require of those who are not?

The panel that follows includes Germany's interior minister and a representative from Amnesty International. They disagree, publicly and at length, about whether Germany is meeting its obligations under the human rights conventions it has signed. The minister argues that there are laws, that the laws must be respected, that migration must be managed. The Amnesty representative argues that the laws are not being followed, that Germany has ten times fewer migrants than in the 1980s, that the devil is in the detail between what the law says and what happens to specific people. A demonstration takes place mid-session: two people hold a large poster and three children stand beside them, asking the minister not to deport children who were born and raised in Germany. A bishop's closing comment reaches back to Exodus: as you were slaves in Egypt, so treat those among you. Human dignity should not be denied to anyone without papers.

III.

The Saturday sessions move between continents with a speed that would be disorienting if the framework were not so consistent. A Bible study at 9:30 in the morning is given by an Indian Jesuit from Kerala who speaks about the story of Hagar and Sarah: how even the outcast woman in the Hebrew scriptures encounters God in the wilderness, how the divine presence is not confined to the chosen but extends to those the chosen have excluded. His theological argument, that Christians carry within them an inherent call to divinity, that the same spirit flows through all branches of the tree whose root is God, is made with extraordinary erudition, drawing on the church fathers, on Ignatius, on biblical texts in their original languages. Three hours later, in a theatre on the other side of the city, a dance company from Hyderabad performs two scenes: a Dalit man who tries to marry across caste boundaries and is drowned, a Dalit woman who asks for her wages and is stripped naked by the landlord who beats her. The performers announce, at the end: these are not stories. These happened. You can read about them in the newspapers.

The afternoon forum on modern India brings together a noted Indian environmentalist, Dalit activists from different regions, a German NGO worker who has spent two decades in Calcutta, and a German government minister. The

discussion ranges across the caste system, globalisation and its discontents, the privatisation of shared water and land, the difference between how India's software industry sees its own country and how the seventy percent of its population living on less than twenty euro cents a day experiences it. The environmentalist speaks of how the unit of pollution accountability should be the corporation, not the nation-state. The Dalit leaders describe the gap between what government schemes promise and what actually reaches the lowest castes after the filters of corruption and discrimination have done their work. The German minister speaks of development aid and strategic partnerships. The gap between these registers, the testimony of those living the crisis and the language of those managing it from above, is itself the session's most eloquent statement.

In the harbour the market of opportunities stretches along the waterfront: hundreds of charity stalls, fair trade stands, advocacy groups, a giant mural anyone can contribute to, a wheel of fortune that tells you where in the world you might have been born. One spin lands on Mali. A fact sheet on Mali is provided. The Africa dialogue on the harbour's floating stage discusses the charismatic churches that have overtaken the historic Protestant denominations across much of the continent, their energy, their local leadership, their rootedness

in African rather than European spiritual culture, alongside the ways in which those same churches have lagged on questions of gender, sexuality, and the structural causes of poverty. Africa, the session implies, is already doing something to Christianity that Europe has not yet understood. The missionaries have reversed direction.

IV.

The closing service on Sunday morning begins at ten, though people have been gathering since nine, laying out their cardboard boxes on the grass, lifting their headphones to receive the translations that will allow sixty thousand people from many countries to follow a service conducted in German. The balloons that line the meadow shift colour as the service proceeds: blue for the first part, then red, then green, faith, hope, love. A Protestant bishop who lives in Rome gives the sermon. He speaks of what Christianity can still offer in an age when Europe can no longer describe itself as Christian, when the tradition's history of violence and complicity is so well documented: not certainty, not superiority, but hope. The hope of a new life, in spite of and not apart from the uncertainty and suffering of the world.

The question, Mensch, wo bist du? Mortal, where are you?, is asked many times throughout the service. Each time,

sixty thousand people answer together: Hier. Here. The word is simple. Its collective utterance is not. Sixty thousand people standing on a meadow in the rain, lifting their voices to say that they are present, that they have not hidden, that they are here and willing to be accountable, this is Christianity doing something that none of the communities described elsewhere in this book can do, because none of them has the numbers. The Eucharist that follows is distributed by hundreds of helpers moving through the crowd with bread and wine; each person dips the wafer into the cup and passes it to the next. A collection is taken for children in Colombia. The service ends with invitations to the next Kirchentag in Dresden, and thanks to the hundred thousand Bremen residents who opened their homes to participants, to the student volunteers who staffed every session, to the translators, the stewards, the people who will clean the meadow afterwards.

Then Bremen empties. A hundred thousand people disperse in two hours. The streets, which have been continuously full for five days, go quiet. On the number 6 tram at eleven the previous night, strangers jammed together in the rain after a late concert spontaneously began to sing, "Havenu Shalom Aleikhem", a Hebrew song of peace, in a German tram, in a city that sixty years ago was part of a state that had tried to erase the people who first sang it. The sign language

dancer at the closing service had interpreted the hymns with a fullness of expression that could be seen from fifty metres away. People said goodbye to the strangers sitting beside them on the cardboard boxes before they left. What a world it would be, the notes say, if everyone behaved like this.

V.

What the Kirchentag offers is solidarity, at a scale and in a key that no other community in this book can match. The solidarity of a small community, the Methodist house group, the Quaker meeting, the Adventist bible study, is personal and local: you know the people you are in solidarity with, you know their names and their situations. The solidarity of the Kirchentag is impersonal and global: you sit beside strangers, you hear testimony from people whose lives you will never encounter again, you answer Hier on behalf of a Christianity that spans two hundred countries and includes people whose political views you probably disagree with. It is solidarity as a posture rather than a relationship, as a commitment to show up rather than a knowledge of who else has shown up.

This distinction matters because the Kirchentag makes visible something that the community chapters can only gesture toward: that Christianity, whatever else it is, is a transnational and intercultural phenomenon that cannot be

adequately understood from inside any single community. The Anglican chaplaincy in Manchester is a beautiful and serious thing. But it does not contain the Indian Jesuit from Kerala reading the Hagar story in its original Hebrew, or the Dalit activists from Hyderabad whose testimonies make the audience go silent, or the Tamil woman who crossed an ocean on a fake passport and found, eventually, safety. The Kirchentag holds all of these simultaneously, in one place, for five days, and then asks everyone: where are you? And expects an honest answer.

A month later, in the Methodist church in Withington, the people who attended the Kirchentag gather to hold a memorial service. They sing the German songs they sang in Bremen. They make paper boats with the children. They present photographs from the harbour stage. The audience, who were not in Bremen, finds it very uplifting. Something of the scale has been carried home in the voices of the people who were there, in the songs that sounded different when sixty thousand people sang them, in the memory of strangers saying goodbye on a wet Sunday morning on a meadow in northern Germany. The Kirchentag does not replace the small community. It reminds the small community of what it belongs to.

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CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Open Door

The Quakers: the Meeting House on Mount Street, Manchester

> *'I say nothing, I just listen. God says nothing, He just listens.'*
>
> , Mother Teresa, quoted during the meeting for worship, Friends Meeting House, January 2008

I.

The Friends Meeting House on Mount Street in Manchester is one of the oldest buildings still standing in the city centre, built in the seventeenth century when the Society of Friends was a persecuted movement whose members were jailed for refusing to swear oaths and for worshipping without an ordained minister. Three and a half centuries later it remains in use, its plain brick exterior unchanged, its interior still arranged for the practice that has defined the tradition since George Fox walked the hills of Derbyshire in 1647 and heard a voice telling him there is one, even Christ Jesus, who can speak to thy condition. The practice is silence.

The Sunday morning meeting for worship at the Friends Meeting House begins at 10:30. There is no minister. There is no liturgy. There is no music. The people who have gathered sit in rows of plain wooden chairs facing each other across an open space, and they are quiet. If someone feels moved to speak they stand and do so, and then sit down, and the silence returns. On the morning recorded in these notes, one person speaks about the Quaker Marjorie Sykes, who spent her life in India alongside Gandhi and Tagore and worked for the education of children. Another speaks of a Russian saying: a hundred friends is worth more than a hundred roubles. Another speaks about the sanctity of life and how rarely we notice its preciousness. Another quotes Mother Teresa on prayer: I say nothing, I just listen. God says nothing, He just listens. Then at 11:30 everyone shakes hands and the meeting is over.

Nothing else in these years of churchgoing resembles this. Every other community in this book has a form: a minister, a text, a structure, a direction in which the service moves. The Quaker meeting has none of these. It has only people sitting together in silence, waiting. What they are waiting for, a prompting from the Inner Light, as the tradition calls it; a sense that something needs to be said; the simple discipline of being present without agenda, is not specified in

advance and cannot be specified. The silence is not the absence of worship. It is the worship itself.

II.

The Society of Friends emerged in seventeenth-century England from a radical rejection of every external religious authority. Fox and the early Friends did not believe that salvation required an ordained clergy, a sacrament, a creed, or a building consecrated for religious use. They believed that the divine light was present in every human being, and that gathering in silence was the most direct way to attend to it. This made them dangerous to the established order: a community that required no priests, no hierarchy, and no oath of allegiance to any earthly institution was a community that could not be easily controlled. They were jailed in large numbers. They refused to remove their hats before judges. They addressed everyone as 'thou' regardless of rank. They refused military service. They refused to pay tithes to a church they did not recognise.

What survived three centuries of this principled awkwardness was a tradition unusually shaped by its convictions. Because the Friends believed the divine light was in everyone, they were drawn early to causes that asserted the equal dignity of all people: the abolition of slavery, prison

reform, the rights of women, the welfare of the poor. Because they refused violence on principle, they were present at every anti-war movement, every campaign for conscientious objection, every effort to find a peaceful resolution to conflict. Because they believed no building was more sacred than another, they opened their meeting houses to whoever needed a room. The building on Mount Street is an expression of this theology made architectural. It is a place of worship that is also a commons.

The notices at the end of the January 2008 meeting convey the breadth of what the building holds: a Thursday social justice group, a Wednesday sitting in silence followed by refreshments, a Bible study on John's gospel, a young Friends group that meets after the main meeting. And a discussion about whether to provide a night shelter for destitute asylum seekers, five beds, space for volunteers to sleep alongside them, open to those with nowhere else to go. The meeting has not yet decided. It is discussing. This too is characteristic: the Quakers make decisions by consensus, waiting in corporate silence until a sense of the meeting emerges. No votes are taken. The process takes as long as it takes.

III.

The building's role in the wider life of the city during these years is striking. In the blog from which this book is drawn, the Friends Meeting House on Mount Street appears not once but sixteen times, and only one of those appearances is a Quaker meeting. The other fifteen are gatherings hosted in its rooms by groups that have nothing to do with the Society of Friends: a Palestine solidarity meeting planning a boycott strategy; a Convention of the Left; a socialist party weekly meeting; a TUC gathering; a Marxism conference; a Libyan solidarity campaign; a public meeting about the 2011 riots; a workers' education seminar; a May Day march that ends with food and Arabic music in the building; a Chinese medicine class; a self-healing course. The building is the venue. The Quakers are the landlords. The cause does not have to be Quaker to be welcome.

This is not incidental to the tradition. It is the tradition's theology expressed spatially. If the divine light is in every human being, then every human struggle for dignity and justice has a claim on the attention of those who believe it. The Palestine solidarity campaigners who meet in the building's rooms are not there despite the Quakers' faith but because of it. The tradition has been present at the edges of political activism since it organised the first petition to the British Parliament against the slave trade in 1783. Its meeting houses

have been safe spaces for dissent for as long as dissent has needed safe spaces. The building on Mount Street continues this in its own quiet way, offering its rooms to whoever is working toward a more just world, whether or not they share a theology.

The spiritual walk through Manchester recorded in an earlier post, a slow meditative walk from the university through the city's streets, pausing at rivers, at crossings, at ordinary urban spaces to ask what lies beneath the surface of a city built for commercial flow, begins at the university chaplaincy but draws on a Quaker sensibility: the idea that the sacred is not confined to consecrated buildings, that walking slowly through a busy street is itself a form of worship, that the city's rivers and forgotten spaces and hurrying strangers are all part of what asks for attention. This is not a specifically Quaker activity. But it is recognisably Quaker in spirit.

IV.

The Quaker meeting house's connection to Buddhist practice is less obvious but genuinely present. The Wednesday afternoon sitting in silence followed by refreshments is a practice that any Theravada Buddhist meditator would recognise. The emphasis on direct experience over doctrine, on interior listening over external authority, on the present

moment as the site of spiritual life, these are qualities shared between early Quaker thought and several strands of Buddhist meditation. The meeting houses in Britain have hosted Buddhist groups and interfaith meditation events for decades, not as a departure from their tradition but as a natural expression of it. A building that believes in the divine light in every person finds it easy to welcome those who seek the same light by different paths.

This connection matters in the context of this book because the Quaker meeting is the place where, for the visitor, the practice of silent sitting first becomes available as a specifically Christian discipline rather than something encountered only in Buddhist or Hindu contexts. Most of the Christian traditions described in these chapters fill every moment of the service with words: hymns, scripture, sermon, prayer, more hymns. The silence in those services, where it appears at all, is brief and functional, a pause before the next element begins. The Quaker meeting reverses this entirely. The silence is not the pause between the words. The words, when they come, are the pause within the silence. The visitor who has been learning to sit in awareness from Buddhist teachers finds, in the plain room on Mount Street, that the Christian tradition contains a version of exactly the same practice, and has done since the seventeenth century.

The Mother Teresa quotation offered during the meeting stays. It is not a Quaker text. Teresa was a Catholic nun from Calcutta whose theology differed from the Society of Friends in almost every particular. But the description of prayer she offers, I say nothing, I just listen; God says nothing, He just listens, captures something the Quaker silence enacts better than any other Christian practice encountered in these years. It is not the silence of waiting for God to speak. It is the silence of two presences attending to each other without needing anything to pass between them. Whether that is prayer or meditation or simply the discipline of being present without agenda, it is the same practice by different names.

V.

The Quaker tradition's primary gift is silence, but silence understood as a practice rather than an absence. Not the silence of having nothing to say, nor the silence of waiting for noise to resume, but the silence of active attention: attending to the room, to the others in it, to whatever stirs beneath the surface of ordinary awareness. This is a learned practice. The children who leave the main meeting at 10:45 for their own programme are being trained in something specific: the capacity to sit still without external stimulus and to find that stillness productive rather than merely empty. Most of the

communities in this book train their members in some form of disciplined attention, to the text, to the body's posture, to the rhythm of liturgy. The Quakers train attention itself.

The consequence of this training is a particular kind of person and a particular kind of community. Because the Friends have no creed to enforce and no minister to interpret, they have historically been more tolerant of internal diversity than most Christian traditions. They have admitted women to full participation since the seventeenth century, not as a progressive reform but as a theological position: if the Inner Light is in everyone, then gender is not a criterion for spiritual authority. They have admitted atheists and agnostics to membership on the same grounds. They have engaged with other religious traditions without requiring conversion. The tradition's boundaries are defined not by what one believes but by whether one can sit in the silence together.

For a visitor who has spent years moving between traditions, encountering the UPC's disciplined bodily practice, the Mormon's cognitive architecture, the evangelical's argument, the Catholic's imaginative richness, the Methodist's communal warmth, the Quaker meeting offers something none of the others offers: permission to arrive without a position. No creed is recited. No decision is demanded. No commitment is invited. One sits in the silence with what one

has and with what one does not yet have, and the meeting holds both equally. The building on Mount Street, which also holds Palestine solidarity meetings and Marxist conferences and Chinese medicine classes, seems to understand that this is what a place of worship is for: not to sort people into those who belong and those who do not, but to remain open, to whatever arrives, from wherever it comes, in whatever condition it finds itself. The limit of this openness is also real, and the Quakers know it. A tradition that locates authority in the Inner Light of every individual, and makes decisions only by consensus, has no mechanism for the situation where someone's Inner Light is telling them something the meeting finds harmful. It has no creed to appeal to, no institution to enforce a ruling, no text whose plain meaning can be invoked. The openness that is its greatest gift is also the source of its characteristic difficulty: it is a tradition that can welcome almost anyone, and cannot easily tell anyone they are wrong.hatever condition it finds itself.

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CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Authority

Who speaks for God, and how that is enforced or contested

I.

Every community in this book has an answer to the question of authority, where the voice of God comes from, who is entitled to interpret it, and what happens when someone disagrees. The answers vary so widely that it is tempting to say they share nothing except the question itself. But the variation is not random. It clusters around a small number of positions, each with a coherent internal logic, each with characteristic virtues and characteristic failures.

The most fundamental distinction is between traditions that locate authority in a text and those that locate it in a person or institution. The evangelical tradition, in all its variety, is text-centred: the Bible is the word of God, and the task of the community is to interpret it correctly. This produces a characteristic intellectual culture, serious biblical scholarship, energetic preaching, extensive lay engagement with scripture, and a characteristic weakness: the text requires interpretation, and interpretation requires interpreters, and interpreters

disagree. The history of evangelical Christianity is in large part a history of splits over what the text means.

The Catholic tradition, by contrast, holds that the text requires authoritative interpretation by the institution, and that the institution, the church, the magisterium, the tradition of councils and popes, is the vehicle through which the Holy Spirit guides the community toward truth. This produces stability and continuity across centuries, and a characteristic weakness: institutions can be wrong, can be corrupted, can serve their own interests while claiming divine sanction. The Vatican's notification against the liberation theologian Jon Sobrino, encountered in the SCM chapter, is an example of institutional authority being used to silence a theologian whose work threatened not doctrine but comfort.

The Quaker tradition represents the most radical answer: authority resides in the Inner Light present in every person, and the community's task is to discern together, in silence, what that light is saying. This produces an extraordinary openness to revision and an extraordinary respect for the individual conscience. Its weakness is that it offers no traction against someone who sincerely believes their Inner Light is telling them something the rest of the community finds harmful. Consensus requires that someone eventually concede.

II.

The Seventh Day Adventist tradition and the LDS both represent a fourth position: authority located in ongoing revelation, in a living prophet or a continuing prophetic tradition that extends beyond the biblical canon. The LDS has its additional scriptures, the Book of Mormon, the Doctrine and Covenants, the Pearl of Great Price, and its living prophet who can receive new revelation. The Adventist tradition has Ellen White, whose voluminous writings are treated as inspired though not as canonical scripture. In both cases the closed canon of mainstream Christianity is opened slightly: the possibility of new divine communication has not been sealed off.

The UPC Pentecostal tradition locates authority differently again: in the immediate experience of the Holy Spirit, in tongues, prophecy, testimony, and the evidence of transformation in a person's life. A sister who has achieved the holiness the tradition calls perfection has a moral authority that no amount of biblical scholarship or institutional position can replicate. She has been where the tradition says one can go. Her life is the argument.

The Kirchentag, as a lay movement, represents an implicit challenge to all clerical authority: it insists that the

questions facing Christianity in the contemporary world, migration, poverty, climate, power, cannot be answered by clergy alone, and that the gathered laity, reasoning together in the light of scripture and conscience, has as much claim to speak as any institution. The SCM makes the same challenge more explicitly, insisting that the tradition's authority must be measured not by institutional consensus but by whether it stands with the poor and the excluded.

III.

What these positions share, beneath their differences, is a common problem: the gap between the source of authority and its application. The text must be interpreted. The institution can err. The Inner Light can deceive. The living prophet can be wrong. The charismatic leader can abuse. Every tradition has a mechanism for closing this gap, scholarship, tradition, communal discernment, the evidence of transformed lives, and every tradition knows, at some level, that the mechanism is imperfect.

The Anglican tradition's response to this problem, encountered in the chaplaincy at St Peters, is perhaps the most honest: it holds the gap open rather than trying to close it. The chaplain who does not specifically relish Paul, who preaches from a text while acknowledging that interpretation is always

partial, who invites the congregation to sit with the question rather than accept the answer, this is not a failure of theological nerve. It is a theological position: that intellectual honesty requires acknowledging what we do not know, and that a faith maintained in full awareness of its uncertainty is more durable than one that can only survive by suppressing doubt.

Authority, then, is not a solved problem in any of the traditions described in this book. It is a live question that each tradition is answering differently, with different consequences for the communities it produces and the individuals it forms. The visitor who moved between these communities encountered, in each of them, a different answer to the question of who gets to speak, and found, in each case, that the answer shaped everything else about how the community understood itself and treated its members.

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CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Body and Boundary

How each tradition shapes physical experience, and who belongs

I.

The body is not incidental to religious practice. It is the site where practice happens: the body that kneels, or stands with hands raised, or sits in silence, or dips a wafer in wine and passes it to a stranger, or speaks in tongues, or colours a Celtic mandala on a table in Chorlton on a Tuesday evening. Each of the communities in this book has a specific relationship with the body, a set of assumptions about what the body is for, what it can be made to do, what it should be disciplined against, and what gifts it might be given.

The UPC Pentecostal tradition has the most demanding bodily regime of any community encountered in this book. Its celibate monk-pastors have given up marriage, reproduction, and the accumulation of property. Its doctrine of entire sanctification holds that the body can be transformed by grace into an instrument of holiness rather than a site of sin. The praise meetings, the singing, the shouting, the raising of hands, the testimonies of transformation, are exercises in bodily surrender: the trained capitulation of the physical self to

the Spirit. What the body does in these meetings is not decoration but theology.

The Adventist tradition disciplines the body through diet, no pork, no alcohol, no tobacco, the weekly sabbath rest, and through the structuring of time. The body that observes the seventh day is a body that has aligned itself with the rhythm of creation. The body that refuses the king's food, like Daniel, is a body that has made its allegiances visible in the most ordinary and daily of choices. Health is not separate from holiness. The body cared for is the body prepared.

The Catholic retreat tradition, encountered at the Jesuit centre, works through the body's capacity for imagination, for vivid inner experience that is as real, in its effects, as external sensation. The Ignatian exercises ask the retreatant to place themselves in scriptural scenes, to feel what the figures feel, to hear what they hear, to be present in the body of the narrative. This is not fantasy or distraction. It is a specific technique for allowing the imagination, which is also a bodily capacity, to be shaped by the tradition's central stories.

II.

The question of who belongs is inseparable from the question of the body, because the boundary of a community is always, in part, a bodily boundary. Who may receive

communion? Whose body is welcome in this space? Whose manner of dress, whose sexuality, whose physical presentation is acceptable? These questions run through every community in this book, and the answers reveal as much about the tradition as any doctrinal statement.

The evangelical Alpha course, with its careful stripping away of denominational distinctives, achieves a maximum of welcome by the same mechanism: it asks nothing of the body at the door. Come as you are. Bring your doubts. No dress code, no prior commitment required. The welcome is genuine and the openness is real. But the course is not without a boundary; it simply locates that boundary at the end rather than the beginning. The invitation at the conclusion of the course, will you decide?, is the moment when the boundary becomes visible.

The SCM's approach to the body and boundary is the most explicit political theology in any community described here. Its sessions on queer theology, on gender and scripture, on masculinity and violence, are all asking the same question: what has the tradition done to bodies that did not fit its normative assumptions, and what would it look like to repair that damage? The transgendered priest who spoke at the SCM conference is a visible answer: a body that the tradition has

historically excluded, now speaking from within it, claiming the tradition's own texts as the ground of her inclusion.

The Quaker tradition draws the most porous boundary of any community in this book. The Inner Light is in everyone; therefore everyone has something to offer; therefore the boundary of the community cannot be drawn too tightly without contradicting the theology. The meeting house on Mount Street is the architectural expression of this: its rooms are open to Palestine activists and Marxist reading groups and Chinese medicine classes and self-healing courses and socialist party meetings, because a building that believes in the divine light in every person cannot turn away those who come seeking something, whatever name they give it.

III.

The three questions, authority, body, boundary, are not separable in practice. The community that locates authority in an ordained priesthood will tend to draw sharp bodily boundaries, because the priest's body matters: its gender, its celibacy or marriage, its ritual purity. The community that locates authority in the Inner Light will tend to draw permeable boundaries, because the light that is in the priest is also in the stranger. The community that disciplines the body through diet and time will tend to produce a strong sense of collective

identity, because shared physical practices are among the most powerful community-forming mechanisms available to human beings.

What the fourteen communities in this book share is not a common answer to any of these questions, but a common seriousness about them. All of them understand that what they believe about God has consequences for how they treat the body, and that how they treat the body has consequences for who they welcome. The differences between them, between the UPC's total bodily discipline and the Quakers' bodily openness, between the Catholic tradition's sacramental body and the evangelical tradition's witnessing body, between the Kirchentag's body of sixty thousand and the Adventist bible study's body of six, are not superficial. They go all the way down.

For the visitor who moved between these communities, the body question was also personal. What did it feel like to stand in a Pentecostal service with hands raised? What did it feel like to kneel before a cross in a Jesuit retreat? What did it feel like to sit in silence for an hour in a Quaker meeting house, or to dip a wafer in wine and pass it to a stranger's lips on a meadow in Bremen? Each of these was a different instruction to the body, a different claim about what the body is for and what it is capable of. The visitor tried, as

honestly as he could, to follow the instruction each community was giving and notice what happened. What happened was different each time. That difference is this book's primary evidence.

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CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Christianity as a Family of Experiments

I.

Fourteen communities. Fourteen different answers to the same questions. And the same person walking between them, sitting in their chairs, eating their food, trying to notice what each one was doing to him and whether what it was doing was true.

What does a seeker find, after five years of this? Not a hierarchy, not one tradition above the rest, not one practice more reliable than the others, not one community closer to whatever the divine actually is. What the seeker finds, instead, is a family. A large, argumentative, internally contradictory, occasionally embarrassing family, whose members share a common inheritance and have made wildly different lives from it.

The word family is not a metaphor for something politer. Families fight. Families exclude. Families have members who do things in the family name that other members find deeply shameful. Christianity's family history includes the Inquisition and the Crusades and centuries of

antisemitism and the blessing of colonial conquest and the systematic abuse of children in institutions run under its authority. The communities described in this book did not do these things. But they exist inside a tradition that did, and some of them are still working out what that means for how they understand themselves.

None of this makes the tradition false. It makes it human. A tradition that was not human, that floated above the history of its own failures, that had no need to repent or reform or reckon with what it had done, would be a different kind of thing entirely, and probably a more dangerous one. The SCM's insistence on being the church ahead of the church, the liberation theologians' preferential option for the poor, the Kirchentag's willingness to put the World Bank president and a demonstration against the deportation of children in the same programme on the same afternoon, these are the tradition's attempts to hold itself accountable to its own best convictions. They are not always successful. They are not insincere.

II.

The word experiments requires some explanation. It is not meant to suggest that these communities are provisional or unserious. The UPC sister who has given up marriage and

property to pursue holiness is not conducting an experiment in any casual sense. The Adventist community that has structured its entire week around the sabbath is not experimenting with a lifestyle choice. These are total commitments, made with full seriousness and maintained over lifetimes.

What makes them experiments is that they are all testing something: a hypothesis about what human life looks like when it is organised around a particular understanding of God. The UPC is testing the hypothesis that total bodily surrender to the Spirit produces holiness. The LDS is testing the hypothesis that a comprehensive revealed cosmology, practised in family and community, produces flourishing. The Quakers are testing the hypothesis that silent communal attention to the Inner Light produces both wisdom and justice. The Alpha course is testing the hypothesis that the core of Christianity can be extracted from its cultural containers and offered to anyone.

These are real experiments in the sense that they have real results, which can be observed and described. The UPC produces communities of remarkable devotion and remarkable rigidity. The LDS produces communities of extraordinary communal warmth and significant pressure to conform. The Quakers produce communities of genuine openness and occasional indecisiveness. The Alpha course produces

something harder to measure: a Christianity that is portable and accessible and perhaps, in being so, slightly thinner than the traditions it distils.

None of these results is the final verdict on the experiment. Communities change. The Kirchentag in 2009 was not the Kirchentag of 1961, divided by a wall. The Church of England in 2012 was not the Church of England of 1662. Every tradition in this book has been different in the past and will be different in the future, because it is made of people who change and a world that changes around them. The experiments are ongoing.

III.

What, then, does the visitor tentatively conclude?

First: that Christianity is not one thing and cannot be evaluated as if it were. The question "Is Christianity true?" or "Is Christianity good?" is too broad to answer, because the word Christianity covers too much territory. Some of what it covers is genuinely beautiful: the Maundy Thursday Seder at St Peters, the singing in many languages at the Kirchentag, the Adventist choir's singing on International Students Day, the Quaker meeting's silence, the Methodist airport chaplain breaking bread so that each person served their neighbour. Some of what it covers is genuinely troubling: the institutional

abuse documented elsewhere in its history, the boundaries drawn against those who do not fit, the authority claims that cannot be questioned without being ejected. Any honest account of the tradition has to hold both.

Second: that the phenomenological lenses used to organise this book, each tradition primarily shaping a particular human capacity, reveal something real. The communities described here are not interchangeable. Each one is doing something particular to the people inside it, cultivating a specific orientation toward the world. Praise and surrender, awareness, conviction, imagination, community, time, conscience, scale, mobility, silence, these are not arbitrary categories. Each of these names something the visitor experienced differently: what it felt like to stand in a Pentecostal service with hands raised, to hold difficult questions open in an Anglican chaplaincy, to be argued into faith by evangelicals, to let a Jesuit retreat work on the imagination, to sit with Methodists who treat fellowship itself as the practice, to keep the Adventist sabbath, to have the SCM make conscience the primary criterion, to stand in a meadow in Bremen with sixty thousand people, to follow the Alpha course through its careful sequence, to sit in Quaker silence for an hour and find it productive. Someone formed by any one of these traditions will approach a problem differently from

someone formed by another, not because one is more intelligent or more devout, but because they have been trained in different capacities.

Third, and most tentatively: that the tradition's sheer variety may be, in some paradoxical sense, its greatest strength. A tradition that has produced both the UPC's total renunciation and the Quakers' radical openness, both the Adventist's sabbath discipline and the Kirchentag's global solidarity, both the Jesuit retreat's imaginative richness and the Alpha course's portable rationalism, such a tradition cannot be easily dismissed or easily captured. It is too large and too various. Its best expressions keep escaping the worst ones. The church ahead of the church, as the SCM puts it, is always somewhere inside the institution, straining forward.

IV.

I began this journey as a Bengali Hindu with a Buddhist practice and a prior Christian experience that I had not yet fully processed. I end it as something that resists simple labelling. I have not converted. I have not joined any of the fourteen communities described here. But I should say plainly what the book has not quite said: that Jesus is not, for me, a subject of study. He is someone I turn to. I ask for his help, and I believe, with a regularity that has long since ceased to surprise me, that

I receive it. His image sits on the small altar in my room in Bangalore, next to the Buddha and Shiva, and the company feels natural rather than contradictory. None of the communities in this book would entirely recognise this arrangement. But it is the honest position from which the book was written, and it belongs in its final pages. I have not found the one true version. I have not concluded that all the experiments are equivalent, or that the differences between them do not matter. I have concluded that the differences matter enormously: that what a community believes about authority shapes what it does with power, that what it believes about the body shapes who it welcomes, that what it believes about belonging shapes whether it is capable of genuine solidarity with those it has historically excluded.

I have also concluded that something is happening in these communities that cannot be fully accounted for by sociology or psychology or the study of religious institutions. Something draws people to spend their Friday evenings in someone's living room with six chairs, singing hymns and studying Daniel's prophecies. Something drew sixty thousand people to stand on a meadow in Bremen in the rain and shout Hier when asked where they were. Something holds the Quaker meeting together across three and a half centuries of a world that has tried, repeatedly, to make silence irrelevant.

What that something is, I cannot say with confidence. I can say that I have been in the room when it was present, and that it felt like something worth taking seriously. I can say that the fourteen communities described in this book are all, in their different ways, attempting to be faithful to it, and that the attempt, for all its failures, is not contemptible.

The experiments continue. The family argues. The map remains incomplete. The seeker keeps walking. He does not walk alone.

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To the university chaplaincy at St Peters, and to its chaplains: more than any other community encountered in these years, this place planted something. The open-mindedness, the quality of the welcome, the permission to stay in the question without being required to resolve it, the willingness to host the interfaith society and the Buddhist meditation class and Abraham's Table alongside the Sunday service, the Maundy Thursday Seder and the SCM conference and the carol service in many languages — all of this was an education in what a religious institution can be when it decides that hospitality is itself a theological act. The visitor arrived in Manchester carrying his Hindu inheritance and a curiosity about religion not yet focused, and found in the chaplaincy a space in which the Buddhist practice that developed alongside and after the Christian encounters could also be welcomed, examined, and held without embarrassment. That breadth of welcome was

not incidental. It was the chaplaincy's whole point. That gift has not been forgotten.

To the Friends Meeting House on Mount Street: the silence was a revelation. Someone formed in Christian schools and Pentecostal praise services and Buddhist meditation practice might have expected to find Quaker silence merely familiar. Instead it was something new: the same stillness, but held communally, and anchored in a tradition that had spent three centuries insisting that silent attention to the divine light in every person was not a retreat from the world but the condition of engaging with it honestly. The Palestine solidarity meetings and the Marxist reading groups and the workers' education seminars that met in its rooms were not a departure from its theology. They were its theology, expressed spatially. That lesson has stayed.

To the Universal Pentecostal Church congregation in Burnage and Liverpool: the three years of Monday evenings were a sustained education in seriousness. The doctrine of perfection asked more than most traditions dare to ask, and the people who had given their lives to it carried it without complaint and without self-pity. The visitor never took water baptism. The brother who invited him to Liverpool before he left did so without reproach. The samosas at the end of the meeting were always excellent.

To the Nigerian Pentecostal fellowship whose music the visitor still listens to regularly, twenty years later. The songs are still good. The welcome was real. What happened in that room in 2003 remains, as the book says, something that cannot be fully accounted for within any single framework. What can be said is that the relationship it began did not end when the visitor left that community. He still makes a point of attending church at Easter and Christmas. He still asks Jesus for help, and believes, more often than he can explain, that it is given. The fourteen communities in this book are not his spiritual home. But Jesus is not a stranger to him, and has not been for a long time.

To the Latter-day Saints missionaries who visited the flat in Wythenshawe with patience and two-part harmonies; to the Jesuit retreat director at Loyola House who played a Simpsons episode and asked what image of God it revealed; to the Anglican chaplains who discussed Paul and the Song of Solomon and the Hebrew structure of the Lord's Prayer and never once made the visitor feel that his questions were unwelcome; to the Seventh Day Adventist choir on International Students Day; to the Methodist minister who broke bread so that each person served their neighbour; to the SCM members who argued that the Gospels required a preferential option for the poor and meant it; to the Quakers

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The visitor arrived in Manchester in September 2002 having grown up in a Catholic school in Lucknow, carrying the prayers and the songs and the liturgical calendar in the furniture of his memory. He left in September 2011 carrying rather more. This book is the attempt to account for what was added.

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